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THE DOCTRINE OF LITERARY FORMS

BY R. K. HACK

Had ancient times conspired to disallow
What then was new, what had been ancient now ?
Or what remained, so worthy to be read
By learned Critics, of the mighty Dead ?

— Pope, *Ep.* 1, 135-138.¹

ONE problem we have always with us. In some blessed fields of research, the investigator may reach results more or less definite, if not definitive; but in the sphere of poetry, of the relation between form and matter in poetic art, wrangling has never ceased, in spite of the great men and great reputations which have been involved in the quarrel. Nor is it likely that the final solution can be attained, for creation and dissension go hand in hand. The poet and the critic are always at war, even when the two activities are combined in the same person; Horace the poet disagrees rather violently with Horace the critic.

All this we may readily admit; yet the historian of literature must not for such reasons abandon the effort to understand the conditions under which poetry has been written, but ought rather to be all the more keen in his effort to discover what effect has actually been exerted on the production of poetry by the contemporary theories of poetry; to judge how far the critical doctrines (for example) to which Horace subscribed really affected his own output of verse and the subsequent course of later poets. It is my belief that the influence of the theory of poetry upon composition has been greatly overestimated; furthermore, that the undue importance assigned to such influence has been largely the result of a single critical doctrine which has been current since antiquity, the doctrine of literary forms.

¹ Pope's translation of Horace, *Ep.* 2, 1, 90-92:

Quodsi tam Graecis novitas invisa fuisset
quam nobis, quid nunc esset vetus aut quid haberet
quod legeret tereretque viritim publicus usus ?

Hence the subject which I wish to investigate in this paper is the doctrine of forms in its application to criticism: first, to sketch the history of the criticism of the *Ars Poetica* of Horace, then to show that there is a basic error in the critical method which has commonly been followed, and lastly to trace that error to its source and to indicate the necessity of a change in critical procedure. For some decades there has been a growing tendency to confine the historian of Latin literature to the pursuit and description of the various genres of literature; there has been a feeling that the whole duty of the modern critic is to classify and to trace the evolution of the *εἶδη* throughout their life, from their origin through their development, until the *εἶδος* decays or is transformed. This conception of literary history has been strikingly expressed by Eduard Norden as follows: "auf Grund dieser Verhältnisse definieren wir die römische Literaturgeschichte als die Geschichte von der Aus- und Umbildung der aus der griechischen Literatur herübergenommenen *γένη*."¹ This definition and the theory on which it is based have won wide acceptance; many monographs and books have been published in which its truth has been taken for granted; and yet it is, I believe, a false conception, based on unsound theory.

It is assumed by those who consent to this definition that the history of Latin literature can be adequately represented by criticism in which primary stress is laid upon form; so that the spiritual and personal qualities of poetry become of secondary importance and are consciously or unconsciously relegated to the background.² The natural and inevitable result of this special emphasis upon form is that the critic comes to assume that poets, and particularly Roman poets, rarely contaminate an established genre by the introduction of new and unconsecrated matter; and in like manner, that the content of a given poem or series of poems is in most cases predetermined by their form.

But another and even more disastrous consequence of this theory is visible in the discussion of originality and imitation, in the vain effort to discover the exact source of every phrase, the exact precedent for every technical procedure which the individual writer happens to em-

¹ *Einleitung in die Altertumswissenschaft*, i, p. 324.

² By form, I mean here all those qualities or 'accidents' of a poem which are imitable: such as the meter, choice of subject, or the happy ending; for these are exterior and mechanical qualities.

ploy. This analysis of source is, we are told, "the highest postulate; only after the borrowed element has been separated from the personal element does it become possible to make a just estimate of the special and personal element."¹ The "postulate" is indeed plausible; but its plausibility is due to a cunning mixture of truth and falsehood. It is certainly true that if we know what has been read or heard by an artist, say Catullus, we are then aware of the literary influences to which he has been subjected and we are justified in making an estimate of the degree of influence exerted by these several sources; but in the actual artistic product of Catullus we are confronted by an entity, and not by an indefinitely divisible assemblage of results. It would therefore be as absurd to put out an edition of Catullus in which all 'allusions' should be printed in red to show how much or how little is original, as it would be to print an edition of *Paradise Lost* in which all the echoes of classical poetry should be distinguished by a similar rubric. It is very important to know the limits of our knowledge. After one has grasped the full meaning of Norden's "höchstes Postulat," one cannot be amazed at the deduction he drew from it; i. e., "that it is extremely difficult to form an estimate of the personality of either Lucretius or Catullus, because we are not acquainted with any corresponding Greek poets or poetry which will afford a basis of comparison!"² I have chosen this citation because it sheds such light on the critical dogma upon which it is founded. By parallel reasoning from these premises, one could easily show that a modern historian would be unable to attempt an estimate of the character of Napoleon, if the records of the lives of Alexander and of Julius Caesar had unfortunately disappeared in 1700.

It remains then for me to state my own critical position with regard to the evolution of genres. I believe that the doctrine of the evolution of genres is unsound, both practically as a critical method and theoretically as a philosophical interpretation of literary truth. The essence of the doctrine of genres has not been affected by its modification under the influence of modern evolutionary thought: the real existence of the genres is presupposed by the very name of the doctrine. For this reason I shall not undertake to trace its recent history, interesting a subject as that is. These recent changes are largely due to the work of such men

¹ *Einleitung in die Allertumswissenschaft*, i, p. 445. ² *Op. cit.*, i, p. 458.

as Taine and Brunetière,¹ who were profoundly stirred by the example of natural science, of men like Darwin and Herbert Spencer. Both good and evil have come from the doctrine of genres, and it is only because the time has now arrived for us to amend and to transcend this doctrine that I have undertaken to criticize it. The duty of the historian of literature is to record the achievements of men in that region of human activity which is called literature. It is the function of erudition to supply correct material for such a record, to furnish the "connaissances exactes, positives, nécessaires pour asseoir et guider nos jugements."² Any critical method which tends to make us regard literature as a matter of externalized form is highly dangerous. The analogy between a species of animal and a species of literature is false: biological methods when applied to literature are unscientific, that is to say they are out of place. One epic cannot in any true sense be said to beget another epic. The *Aeneid* is not by the *Annales* out of the *Argonautica* out of the *Odyssey* out of the *Iliad*.

What excuse then have critics, some of undoubted genius, had for seeking to apply such a dogma to the history of Latin literature? The answer is found in the notorious dependence of Latin letters on Greek, so often announced by the Romans themselves; in the strong tendency of the Roman race to reduce everything to rule and to legislate not merely for the material but for the spiritual world; and in a great philosophy which we shall later have to discuss. It is a piece of Roman legislation that I wish now to examine, a law to whose influence the term has not yet been fixed.

The *Ars Poetica* of Horace has been in direct relation to critical theory for a longer time than even the *Poetics* of Aristotle.³ It has accumulated a vast bulk of commentary, nearly comparable to that which centers about Homer; it has occasioned among its commentators an acrimony of dispute and a sustained ability to differ which might easily dishearten those who hope for an objective science of

¹ Cf. F. Brunetière, *L'Évolution des genres dans l'histoire de la littérature*, p. 18: "Nous pourrions dire qu'à la critique fondée sur les analogies qu'elle présente avec l'histoire naturelle de Geoffrey Saint-Hilaire et de Cuvier, nous nous proposons de voir si l'on ne pourrait pas substituer, ou ajouter pour la compléter, une critique à son tour qui se fonderait sur l'histoire naturelle de Darwin et de Haeckel."

² Cf. G. Lanson, *Histoire de la littérature française*, p. vii.

³ Cf. Spingarn, *History of Literary Criticism in the Renaissance*, p. 11.

criticism. I believe, however, that some shape of truth will emerge from a summary of previous criticism, and I shall attempt to show that quarrels have arisen from a fundamental error, from the tendency of critics to elevate into an explanation of the whole *Ars Poetica* that particular aspect of the poem by which each has been most impressed.

It is worth noticing that in ancient times no question was raised concerning its status as an *ars* or as a letter. Quintilian repeatedly referred to it as the *Ars Poetica*.¹ It seems reasonable to conclude that the controversy did not then exist, and that the poem was accepted simply and uncritically as a part of Horace's work which was suitable to be read in school; it was didactic material dealing with poetry, and there is no sign that Quintilian was aware, when he employed the term *Ars Poetica*, of all the implications which would later be read into that title. The only other ancient writer who tells us anything of value is Porphyrio, who says that Horace "*congressit praecepta Neoptolemi τοῦ Παιδανῶς de arte poetica, non quidem omnia, sed eminentissima.*" Upon this slight foundation Nettleship built his interesting but unsound attempt to discriminate between Aristotelian and post-Aristotelian portions of the *Ars Poetica*.²

The modern history of the *Ars Poetica* begins of course in the Renaissance, when men ceased to accept and began to criticize, when the effort was made to "re-establish the aesthetic foundations of literature."³ Hence came the flood of treatises on poetry, and Horace ran Aristotle hard for the place of highest authority. It was necessary to justify poetry against mediaeval scorn and hatred; to this end critics had constant recourse to the arguments of Horace.⁴ Thus the *Ars Poetica* became the textbook of a propaganda; and Minturno admonished his readers "*che gli ammaestramenti del dottissimo Orazio recarci a memoria dobbiamo.*"⁵ But it soon became obvious that the poem

¹ *Ep. ad Tryph.*, 2; *Inst.* viii, 3, 60.

² It is unsound, because the words of Porphyrio do not entitle us to conclude that there was anything more than a general resemblance between the doctrine of Neoptolemus and of Horace. The relation of Aristotle to his followers will be discussed later.

³ Spingarn, *op. cit.*, p. 3.

⁴ Spingarn, *op. cit.*, p. 11: "The more strict defence of poetry was attempted for the most part on the grounds set forth by Horace in his *Ars Poetica*."

⁵ *Arte Poetica*, p. 95.

lacked some of the qualities which a textbook ought to possess: its apparent desultoriness was sure to provoke enemies, so that we find J. C. Scaliger saying “*De Arte quaeris quid sentiam? — Quid? Equidem de Arte sine arte tradita.*”¹ This is significant of the vital change that had occurred since antiquity in men’s attitude toward the *Ars*; and the course of subsequent criticism is prefigured by these two types, the one who believes that the poem is a perfect *ars*, the other who believes that Horace indeed intended to write a perfect *ars*, but failed disastrously.

The first opinion not only had numerous supporters during the Renaissance,² but was still defended in the eighteenth century, and has recently been revived in full vigor. The phraseology of Regelsberger (1797) is typical: “*L’art poétique d’Horace, dans un ordre nouvellement découvert, formant le poème didactique le plus accompli de l’antiquité, chef-d’œuvre de poésie et de brièveté.*”³ N. A. Heiden (1815) was obviously unwilling to be outdone by his predecessors in the task of heaping up laudation. “Man findet darinnen alles,” says he, “was die Stoiker und Akademiker der Griechen herüber schönes gesagt haben . . . Die reine Vernunft ist seine einzige Führerin . . . Ein wahres Meisterstück . . . Klarheit, Simplicität, Mannigfaltigkeit, Präcision und Gründlichkeit herrschen darinnen vom Anfang bis zum Ende.”⁴ Within the last few years, however, few have ventured to follow this lead until Norden published an important article reaffirming the old view with some modern variations.⁵ I shall take up Norden’s arguments later.

The second class of critics started always with the same pre-supposition: i. e., that it was the intention of Horace to write a perfect didactic poem; but like Scaliger they found it to be an excessively artless art, and they resorted to various devices to explain away the difficulty. D. Heinsius (1605) was the first to transpose passages which he thought

¹ Scaliger, *Poet.*, vi, 7.

² Cf. H. B. Charlton, *Castelvetro’s Theory of Poetry*, p. 12: “The predominant influence in Vida is that of Horace; with him, Horace becomes the dictator of the early Renaissance critics, such as Dolce and Daniello.”

³ Cf. F. Schoell, *Hist. de la litt. rom.*, p. 395, who justly calls the work of Regelsberger a “*morceau curieux de dialectique.*”

⁴ *Anleitung zur Kenntniss der Dichtkunst des alten Roms*, pp. 260 ff.

⁵ Cf. Cruttwell, *History of Roman Literature*, p. 295.

were not in logical sequence; Bentley and Peerlkamp quite naturally adopted a method so congenial to their conjectural bent; and they have been followed by Ottema and Ribbeck. Ribbeck is (and one hopes will remain) the last example of this type. Among other transpositions, he puts ll. 24-30 after 1; 37, 408-418 plus 295-308 after 72; 86-98 after 322, and so on indefinitely. After making this collection of *disiecta membra*, he passes the following judgment upon his work: it is "wie ich hoffe, eine wohldurchdachte, abgerundete Reihe zusammenhängender Sätze und Gedanken mit feinen, sicheren Übergängen."¹ What Horace wrote was difficult to understand; therefore Ribbeck concluded that Horace had not written it, and proceeded to substitute a new *Ars Poetica* of Ribbeck for the original poem. The substitute, being the product of Ribbeck's own intellect, was comprehensible to Ribbeck; and his praise of it was mere self-laudation. Dacier and P. Hardouin deserve mention under this head: Dacier fancied that Horace had composed the *Ars Poetica* bit by bit at various times, but had died before he could review the fragments and cement them together; Hardouin solved the problem in the fashion characteristic of him by courageously denying that Horace was the author.² It is plain that all these hypotheses tend toward the demolition and not toward the interpretation of the poem; Hardouin was more logical, rather than more stupid, than others of the same school.

One obvious way out of the dilemma was to refuse to recognize the poem as an *ars*, and to explain its lack of complete logical structure by attributing to it some particular and private purpose. Robortelli, one of the early editors of Aristotle's *Poetics*, was perhaps the first of this class of critics; the list is long, and includes most of the modern editors of Horace—Baxter, R. Hurd, Sanadon, Engel, Wieland, Colmans, Ast, F. A. Wolf, J. Dunlop, Bernhardt, Welcker, Lehrs, O. Weissenfels, Vahlen, Orelli, Kiessling, Page, Palmer, Wilkins, Wickham.³ Baxter supposed that the *Ars Poetica* was a satire directed against the Roman theatre; Engel, that Horace satirizes both poets and contemporary critics. Wieland (1782) developed and modified this hypothesis; and

¹ Otto Ribbeck, *Episteln und Buch von der Dichtkunst*, p. 252.

² Cf. Lamarre, *Hist. de la litt. lat.*, ii, p. 371.

³ For a fuller bibliography see Teuffel-Schwabe, and the article by Stemplinger in Pauly-Wissowa, s. v. Horatius.

was the first to emit a guess which Colmans (1783) and Dunlop (1827) eagerly adopted: i. e., that Horace wrote the *Ars Poetica* in answer to a request of the father of the Pisones, who, like the mother of Agricola, was afraid that his son would devote himself too ardently to an un-Roman pursuit, in this case the composition of dramas. Hence Horace wrote the *Ars Poetica* in order to discourage a young man from writing poetry! Wieland's theory has met acceptance in some degree with many subsequent critics, as e. g., Orelli and Patin; but aside from his theory it is true that all the critics of this class discover some satirical and polemic intention in the poem.¹

Naturally the traditional title has not found favor in their eyes, because it seems to them to imply a complete didactic treatment of the subject: they have therefore insisted that the poem is an *epistula*, and is to be judged by the "laws" of that genre. A letter (they say), following the laws of conversation, may and should be loose in structure; and from this point of view the best explanation of the poem has been given by O. Weissenfels.² Weissenfels says that the critic must have always before his eyes "die Eigentümlichkeit der Literaturgattung" to which this letter belongs; that Horace is "kein reiner Dichter" and would therefore have been unable to display his talent in "einer jener reinen, ungemischten Dichtgattungen";³ that he was as Lessing says a "philosophic poet," but that he was not an "*a priori* poet," for he knew his limitations. Personally, I am far from sure what an *a priori* poet is; but as the phrase is used by Weissenfels, it seems to imply merely that Horace had some common sense.

Weissenfels quotes with approval Lehr's paradox, that the letter is the "Form der Formlosigkeit"; he finds nevertheless that Horace steps over "das erlaubte Mass" in his "Willkür," and adopts an hypothesis very similar to Dacier's, "dass Horaz manche von den Vorschriften, namentlich im zweiten Teil der Epistel, völlig gesondert von einander und einzeln in Verse gebracht hat." If all of Weissenfels' monograph were of this nature, it would not have contributed anything new or valuable to previous opinions; but he makes the acute statement that "every work of art must carry in itself the key to its understanding,"

¹ Patin, *Oeuvres d'Horace*, ii, pp. 462-464.

² *Neues Lausitzisches Magazin*, lvi, pp. 118-200.

³ *Loc. cit.*, p. 123.

a principle which would have prevented numerous errors if he had adhered to it.¹ He also points out the folly of regarding the *Ars* as the mere product of a fantasy of Horace's friend Piso, and rightly insists that the poet's own character is the real cause of the epistles. He concludes with an apology for the preponderance of *formal* considerations in the *Ars Poetica*, which he says is accounted for by two reasons: first, that the very nature of aesthetic problems makes it easier to talk of the outer appearance of art rather than of its inner secrets; second, that form always meant more to the ancients than it does to us. The meaning of this last remark, which is usually accepted as a truism, will be brought out to some extent further on in this paper.

Norden stated his position on the *Ars Poetica* in 1905,² and has since emphatically reaffirmed it. His thesis merits our most careful study, not only because of its own thoroughness, but because he represents the biological, scientific method of criticism in its most developed form. The essential points in his thesis may best be given as commentary upon the subjoined scheme of the *Ars Poetica*, which is taken from his article.

- I. De arte poetica 1-294.
 - A. De partibus artis poeticae 1-130.
 - 1. De argumentorum tractatione et inventione 1-41.
 - 2. De dispositione 42-44.
 - 3. De elocutione 45-130.
 - a. De verbis singulis 45-72.
 - b. De verbis continuatis (de metris) 73-85.
 - c. De verborum coloribus 86-130.
 - B. De generibus artis poeticae 131-294.
 - Transitio 131-135.
 - 1. Epos 136-152.
 - 2. Drama 153-294.
 - Propositio 153-155.
 - a. Die griechischen *εἶδη* 156-250.
 - α. Tragödie u. Komödie 156-219.
 - β. Satyrspiel 220-250.
 - b. Σὺγκρισις des griechischen u. römischen Dramas 251-294.
 - α. In der Form 251-274.
 - β. In den *εἶδη* 275-294.

¹ *Op. cit.*, p. 130.

² *Hermes*, xl, pp. 481-528.

II. De poeta 295-476.

Transitio (295-305) + Propositio (306-308).

A. De instrumentis poetae 309-332.

B. De officio poetae 333-346.

C. De perfecto poeta 347-452.

1. Das Postulat möglichster Vollkommenheit 347-407.

2. Seine Erfüllung durch ernstes Studium 408-452.

D. De insano poeta 453-476.

The symmetry of this scheme is apparent at a glance. I shall try to summarize the argument upon which it is based; although a large part of Norden's proofs consist of mere assertions.

"The problem of the *Ars Poetica* has been attacked in three different ways. The first and oldest, that of transposition to restore order, needs no refutation. The second solution, that there is intentional lack of order, required by the genre (*sermo* or *epistula*), is unsound. The third, which aims to find the order really present, was first employed by Vahlen; but was only carried as far as l. 118. Horace took over this order from the practice of other τέχναι; e. g., Quintilian, who in 2-11 deals with *ars oratoria*, but in 12 takes up the *orator*. Horace in the first 130 lines treats of *inventio*, *dispositio*, *elocutio*; which are three out of the five *partes rhetorices* enumerated in Quin. 3, 3. Lines 131-294 deal with epic and drama, which are *genera* of poetry corresponding to the three *genera causarum* in oratory (*oratio laudativa*, *deliberativa*, *iudicialis*).

1-41 deal with *tractatio* and *inventio*; which are practically identical terms. 45-72 deal with the ἐκλογὴ ὀνομάτων. The *colores verborum* must conform to the εἶδος (86-98), to the πάθη (99-113), and to the ἥθη (114-130). 156-250 deal with the Greek εἶδη of the drama. 156-178 appear to repeat 114 ff., how shall these lines be classified? The explanation is to be found in the purpose of Horace; in the first passage he was handling the ἥθος of the diction, here he treats of the character-drawing as such in the dramatic γένος, without regard to diction. In like manner is solved the problem of 79-81 and 251-274, both of which passages deal with the iambus; for in 79-81 the ἥθος of the iambus was related to λέξις, whereas here we are concerned with the development of the iambus within the dramatic γένος.

309-332 deal with the *instrumenta poetae*; 333-346, *de officio poetae*, must be compared with Quin. 3, 5, 2; Cic. *de inv.* 1, 6; and *de Or.* 1, 138, 213.

345-347 deal with the postulate of perfection and show how it may be reached through *studium* and *labor* (408-452). 453-476 are added for the sake of contrast. Compare Cic. *de Or.* 3, 54.

The preceding analysis has conclusively shown that Horace founded his treatment of the subject upon a twofold division according to the principle *ars* (Poetik) — *artifex* (Dichter). We have therefore to inquire to what sphere of literature this principle specially belongs. The answer can be found by collecting instances of other works in which the same bipartite division is employed. Quintilian is the most conspicuous example; but there are plenty of such works in various fields. In music, we have Bacchius, who wrote an *εἰσαγωγή τέχνης μουσικῆς*, as well as Boethius, *de Instit. Mus.* In philosophy, Albinus, *εἰσαγωγή εἰς τὴν τοῦ Πλάτωνος βίβλον*. In medicine, we have an isagogic treatise once attributed to Galen (19, 346 ff. K.) and also pseudo-Soranus *ad filium* (Rose, *Anecd. gr. et gr.-lat.*, II, p. 243). This latter is very important, because the author speaks more fully than any other concerning the principle of isagogic composition, which he defines as "introductio doctrinae cum demonstratione primarum rationum ad medicinae artis conceptionem."

Frontinus (*Agrimens.* 1, 64, Lachm.) says "uno libro instituimus artificem, alio de arte disputavimus." Lucian's treatise *περὶ ὀρχήσεως* is constructed precisely as is the *Ars Poetica*. §§ 6-34 deal with the *τέχνη*, § 35 with the *ὀρχηστής*.

All these instances go to show that the principle followed by Horace was a fixed convention. The genre was probably established in Rome under Stoic influences; and we are entitled to call it the isagogic genre. We need a full collection of material; but we can already state a few conclusions which are important for the criticism of Horace's poem.

1. True *εἰσαγωγαί* give the results of scientific research, in shape comprehensible to the beginner. They therefore form a didactic supplement to '*paraenetisch-protreptische Literatur*'! Their characteristic motives are '*Alter, Erfinder, Zweck, Teile, Begabung, etc.*' These motives are all present in the *Ars Poetica*; therefore the poem is isagogic.

2. Use of question and answer is not obligatory in this genre, but is extremely popular. Compare *A. P.* 326 ff., which is a short extract from a humorous but perfectly regular *εἰσαγωγή εἰς ἀριθμητικὴν*.

3. Such treatises had to be addressed to some one. The Romans, whose family affections were stronger [*sic*] than was the case in Greece, chose by preference their own son or the son of a friend.

4. A history of the genre cannot be written until materials have been collected. The sophists probably popularized the genre; they transferred it into prose from poetry, for its career is likely to have begun with the pseudo-Hesiodic *Χίρωνος ὑποθήκαι*.

5. Posidonius wrote an *εἰσαγωγή περὶ λέξεως*. Compare *A. P.* 45-130.

6. Varro, under Stoic influence, wrote an epistle for Pompey in the isagogic form (Aulus Gellius, 14, 7). The genre rapidly became popular at Rome.

We conclude that Horace was urged to compose a poem in the isagogic genre by the new developments of Roman poetry. A generation had sprung up in leisure, without the hard training of necessity. So art had lost its gravity, and poets esteemed but did not criticize themselves; Horace raised a warning voice. The form was given him by tradition. He had no son of his own, and was forced to address a friend's son. This didactic letter is more Greek than any other of his writings; only the varnish is Roman. A Greek paraphrase would be the best commentary. Horace had never read [*sic*] the *Poetics* of Aristotle, and traces of that influence are very slight.¹ The *Ars Poetica* unfortunately had no practical success; that is to say, it did not affect the later development of Roman poetry. Ovid composed in the very style which Horace had forbidden."

So ends this perfect specimen of scientific criticism. Let me say at once that I have no intention of attempting to refute all of Norden's conclusions. It is infinitely more important for our study of the history of criticism to understand how Norden arrived at such conclusions, and upon what assumptions his argument is based; for if this method and these assumptions can be shown to be false, then the whole superstructure will fall with them. It must, however, be said that the twofold

¹ *Vide infra*, p. 61.

division of the poem, upon which his attribution to the isagogic genre is entirely dependent, is absolutely untenable. *Ars* and *artifex* are not, of course, two independent concepts, but are in close and logical relationship one with the other. It would tax the powers of a greater than Horace to write 294 hexameter verses on the subject of the art of poetry without ever mentioning the poet. Horace as a matter of fact did not achieve this impossible feat; for he expressly addresses the poet in 14, 24, 38, 45, 87, 119, 120, 125, 129, 136, 153, 178, 183, 188, 234, 270, 290. Yet to cite particular verses is to fall partially into the same error; the truth is well stated in Vahlen's words, that "Dichter und Dichtung gleicherweise durch das ganze Gedicht gehen und beide in mancherlei Form verwendet werden."¹ It would be difficult enough to write a chapter on the ideal chemist in which no reference should be made to chemistry; but it is certain that in the case of poetry, the art and the artist cannot be mechanically sundered. Norden's separatist argument really implies that a poem is conceivable without a poet.

It is clear that the *Ars Poetica* does not lend itself to such analysis, and that Norden's main thesis is unsound.² It would be possible to go over his scheme in detail; but once the illusory antithesis *ars-artifex* is banished, the examination of minor points is a waste of time.³ Plainly the *Ars Poetica* refuses to be confined within the trammels of the isagogic genre.

We have now surveyed the course of modern criticism of the *Ars Poetica*; and we have seen how various fancied or real qualities of the poem itself have forced its critics into different groups. At first, they all assumed that it belonged to the didactic genre. On this assumption, it received hyperbolic praise from men like Minturno and Heiden; on the same assumption, it was enthusiastically condemned by men like Scaliger and Heinsius. Then a fresh turn was given to criticism by the suggestion that the poem really belonged to the epistolary genre; so that for the last century critics have been divided into two great schools. The first school comprises those who believe that Horace

¹ J. Vahlen, *Sitzungsb. der k. pr. Akad.*, 1906, pp. 589-614.

² Norden's thesis has been thoroughly disproved by Vahlen in the article quoted above.

³ For example, Norden assigns 1-37 to the rhetorical category of *tractatio*. But the subject of 1-37 is unity; and it may be seen by referring to Cic. *de Or.* 2, 177, that *tractatio* has to do with *variety* of treatment, and not with unity.

intended to write a didactic treatise on poetry, and the second those who believe that he wrote a mere epistle which must be judged by the less stringent laws of that genre. What have these two schools in common? The gulf between their views is apparently wide and deep; and we have on record approximately four centuries of rather bitter polemic. Norden and Weissenfels, whom I have selected as perhaps the most able modern representatives of the two groups, disagree not only concerning the genre, but also concerning the purpose, the sources, the style, and almost all the details of the analysis of the *Ars Poetica*.

Now one expects opinions and tastes to differ, but such a difference as this is not trivial, nor can it be lightly disregarded by students *utriusque sermonis* on the ground that one school or the other is destined to extinguish its rival at some future date. Consequently if it can be proved that these schools are in reality one, that their different interpretations are founded upon identical axioms, that these axioms are themselves insecure and the fatal source of divergent criticism, then we may hope for true progress in the study of this and similar problems, instead of an uneasy oscillation between two irreconcilable opinions.

Such proof is now I believe within our reach. Close examination of the arguments of Norden and Weissenfels reveals the fact that both lay primary emphasis upon the *form* of the poem. According to them, it is the form that determines the content. Their course of reasoning may be put as follows:

Norden: *The Ars Poetica is an εἰσαγωγή.*

All εἰσαγωγαί are written in strict accordance with a fixed rhetorical scheme.

Therefore the Ars Poetica is written in strict accordance with a fixed rhetorical scheme.

Weissenfels: *The Ars Poetica is an epistula.*

All epistulae are written in a loose conversational style.

Therefore the Ars Poetica is written in a loose conversational style.

In this wise the Protean miracle is wrought: the same body of verse which is judged by the first school to be "flawless, a true *chef-d'œuvre*, the perfect didactic poem," transforms itself and appears to the second school as "careless conversation, the *Form der Formlosigkeit*." Their premises differ, their conclusions differ; only the *Ars Poetica* remains

the same. The miracle is therefore external to it, and is performed in the mind of its critics. How can it be defined?

We have seen that both schools, in judging literature, desire first of all to establish the form of literature with which they have to do in each particular case. We have also become aware that intelligent critics, employing this method of *formal* criticism, reach results so divergent as to preclude any logical compromise. It is moreover apparent that we have attained a stage in our argument where the doctrine of literary forms again emerges, this time as the cause of incurable confusion in a concrete case chosen from the field of Roman literary history. Incurable, that is, just so long as critics consider themselves bound to attach the label of a definite genre to every work in poetry and prose; just so long as they believe that this generic label carries with it by necessary implication a long train of judgments to be made upon and qualities to be discovered in each work so labelled. It is plain that a genuine scientific method leads, wherever it is applicable, to general agreement among scientists upon a body of ascertained fact; it is equally plain that this method of literary criticism does not lead to such agreement, although we have been in possession of the facts for more than nineteen centuries. Furthermore, since classifications are notoriously easy to make,¹ since at any moment some imaginative student may conceive yet another genre and insist that both of the old schools are wrong, we run a decided risk of spending the future in the pursuit of classifications rather than in the scrutiny of individual works. I do not therefore think it presumptuous to question the validity of the method; on the contrary, I hold that it is of high importance to the truth and value of our study of ancient literature that this method be comprehended in its origin and subsequent development, in order that we may appraise the good and the evil which have attended its employment.

Now the doctrine of literary forms or genres has admittedly been based upon ancient theory, and we have an excellent opportunity to

¹ Cf. William James, *The Principles of Psychology*, ii, p. 646: "It is, for some unknown reason, a great aesthetic delight for the mind to break the order of experience, and class its materials in serial orders, proceeding from step to step of difference, and to contemplate untiringly the crossings and inosculation of the series among themselves."

examine an ancient presentation of that doctrine in the very poem of Horace which has caused so long a quarrel in modern times. I shall attempt (1) to formulate the critical theory subscribed to by Horace, so far as he can be said to subscribe to a theory who boasted that he was "*nullius addictus iurare in verba magistri*";¹ (2) to compare his theory as a critic with his practice as a poet, in order that we may know to what extent his doctrine determined his action; (3) to discuss the relation between the theory of Horace and the *Poetics* of Aristotle. In this way, it will be possible to apply a practical test to the doctrine of literary forms; the fact that the poet and the critic is the same man affords us the ideal conditions for such a test.

In the endeavor to formulate the theory of criticism held by Horace, we must constantly bear in mind that his character is pre-eminently pragmatic, that his tendency is always to insist upon results rather than processes. His universe is for the most part controlled by active personalities and not by abstractions. So far as he can, he substitutes the legislator for the legislation; when he cannot do that, he uses the device we call personification. In a jesting account of his conversion from Epicureanism, he does not yield to argument, as a Greek would have done; but he is "compelled to steer again in the abandoned course" by Diespiter, who has "driven through a clear sky the horses of thunder."² It is therefore only fair to make the same proviso in regard to Horace's theory, that Aristotle makes in regard to his study of ethics — *παιδευμένου γάρ ἐστιν ἐπὶ τοσούτων τὰκριβὲς ἐπιζητεῖν καθ' ἕκαστον γένος, ἐφ' ὅσον ἡ τοῦ πράγματος φύσις ἐπιδέχεται*. I shall therefore assume in examining the *Ars Poetica* and other writings that the label, that questions of classification, are of no moment whatever; that Horace is expressing his personal opinions in the *Ars Poetica*, and that these opinions are not made any less his own by the fact that Horace is addressing the Pisones.

Horace begins the *Ars* with a sketch of a mad painter and ends with a sketch of a mad poet. The painter is mad because he sets a human head upon the neck and shoulders of a horse; the poet is mad because for some reason he cannot or will not accept and profit by criticism. The painter is employed to introduce and the poet to drive home the central lesson which Horace desires to inculcate in the hearts

¹ *Ep.* I, 1, 14.

² *Od.* I, 34, 4 ff.

of all who aspire to poetry: 'follow propriety as your guiding star, and submit yourself utterly to those men who can teach you what in each and every case is proper.' From this principle of the all-nourishing, all-informing virtue of propriety, which was to Horace an ardent emotional conviction as well as an intellectual dogma, flow every word and phrase in the poem, all the high lights of vivid denunciation and all the apparent digressions into Greek and Roman literary history. Upon examining the *Ars* in detail, we find therein essential unity, the unity which is conferred on a writer by strong feeling and conviction; we shall not find the unity of strict logical structure. It would be and is absurd to expect of Horace the same mental qualities which we should rightly demand from the author of a scientific treatise. Bearing this in mind, let us proceed with the analysis.

You would laugh to scorn (he says) such a wild picture; for it will be mere *vanae species*, images which have no basis in fact, which have no *una forma* to explain and maintain them (1-9). Painters and poets are entitled to be daring, and have what we call poetic license: but they must not exceed the limits of that license by assembling things which do not belong together (9-13). Purple patches are bad because they are not in their proper place (14-22).¹ You must have unity; but you cannot have unity if you push a virtue into excess; and to avoid excess you need *ars* (23-31). *Ars* requires that you be successful not only in a few details, but in the total representation; do not therefore take on a piece of work too large for your powers (32-40). If you suit the work to your powers, then you will have eloquence and order; by order, I mean saying the right thing in the right place (40-45). Do not be carried away by eloquence into the invention of many new words; it is enough to rearrange old words (46-48). If however you are forced to find a new word for a new discovery, you may have a little freedom, but your new words must really be old Greek words slightly altered; I claim this liberty for myself and Virgil and Varius, just as much as for Plautus and Ennius (48-59). For truly words are like leaves and human beings: they are born, flourish and decay, according to the decrees of *usus*, which governs all speech and makes all decisions (60-72). Homer instituted the *usus* of writing epic in hexameter; in elegiac

¹ Horace seems to be hitting contemporary poets; men like Julius Montanus, who was famous for his 'sunrises.' See Ovid, *Pont.* 4, 16, 11; Seneca, *Ep.* 122.

meter plaintive poetry was at first in solitary confinement, since then thankful utterances (*voti sententia compos*) have been shut up with it; but the grammarians' quarrel concerning the name of the first authority for elegiacs is not yet settled (73-78). Anger turned its proper weapon, the iambus, over to Archilochus; later comedy and tragedy borrowed it: and the Muse allowed lyric poetry the following subjects — gods and demigods, winners in the games, the love-troubles of young men and gentlemanly drinking (79-85). If I cannot abide by the meter and style assigned to each subject I have no right to be called a poet (86-88). You must not express comic matter in tragic form, for that would shatter propriety; and yet a tragic character must sometimes use the plain talk reserved for comedy, if you wish him to reach the spectator's heart (89-98). For poetry must not be merely beautiful, but must stir the emotions; in order to accomplish this you must correctly represent the emotion in the actor (99-105). A sad man talks sadly, an angry man threatens; nature is the cause of the emotion which the tongue must translate; be sure that your actors speak in harmony with their characters (105-118).

You may either follow tradition or create new and self-consistent characters; if you choose the second and risky course, see that your characters never change or "grow" from beginning to end (119-127). The second course is risky, because it is hard to transfer general ideas into a particular form; you'll do better to adapt some of the *Iliad*: you can make what you thus borrow really your own, by not imitating with painful closeness, and by avoiding conceit (128-139).¹ Homer was not conceited; he always performs what he promises and always preserves propriety even when lying (140-152).² I repeat that if you want an audience you must preserve propriety in your characters; young men must talk and act like young men, old men like old (153-178).³ The action on the stage must be lively, but not improper; no vulgar murders, or I shall be bored; five acts is the proper length; no gods allowed unless necessary to solve the tangle; do not break the

¹ Cf. Hermogenes: "πῶς κοινὰ . . . ἰδιώσομεν"; in his π. μεθ. δεινότητος, 29. Horace carries his *odi profanum vulgus* into art: cf. *Ep.* 1, 3, 11, where he bids the poet "shun the *lacus et rivos apertos*." Pollianus, *Anth. Pal.* 11, 130, has "τοὺς κυκλίους μισῶ, λωποδύτας."

² Cf. Aristotle, *Poetics*, 1460 A: οὐκ ἀγνοεῖ δὲ δεῖ ποιεῖν αὐτόν.

³ Cf. *Poetics*, 1454 A: τὸ ἀρμόττοντα.

three-actor rule (179-192). The chorus also must say the proper thing (193-201). The music was more decorous of old than it is now, as was the audience; the audience is now too numerous and mixed; hence the change in music and in style, which has become oracular (202-219).¹ This same change in the audience has forced the tragic poet to write Satyr plays, stuff unworthy of the dignified matron *Tragoedia*; but let it be as little unworthy as possible, let it not degenerate into comedy (220-239). For my part, I shall work over old material for my poetry, and the result will be very good; any one would say he could do as much; but if he tries it he will sweat in vain, so cunning is my art of fitting and joining; old material indeed, but rendered glorious by art (240-243). But I was talking about Satyr plays: they must not be too vulgar, or the best people will not approve; the iambus is the proper meter for them, only do not handle it the way our old untrained poets did; they did not have good criticism, and we've been too easy with our poets (244-264).

Shall I avail myself of current bad taste to write badly? Of course not; but even if I do not commit positive improprieties, I am not therefore good but merely faultless; to be really good, study and imitate the Greeks (265-269). 'Your forefathers were satisfied with Plautus?' The more fools they — but they would not have made that error had they been acquainted with the Greek models, from Thespis to old comedy, which by the way became too free and had to be suppressed (270-284). Our elder poets deserve credit for having tried to adapt all sorts of Greek work, particularly for not being such slavish imitators as to write only of Greek deeds and leave our own unsung; but every one of them was lazy and careless in polishing off (285-291). Our poets must use severe measures and never neglect form; instead, they listen to Democritus, who says "poets are inspired by heaven"; so they straightway grow long hair and trim their nails no more (291-301)!² I envy them; if I were not a sane artist, I should write beautiful inspired poetry: but since I am sane, I shall devote myself to showing others how to compose not inspired nonsense but proper

¹ Cf. Plato, *Laws*, 659; and Athen. *Deipnos*, 617 C.

² Cf. Dio Chrys. 53, 1, on Homer; Cic. *de Div.* 1, 37, 80; Plato, *Ion* 533; *Phaedr.* 245. Aristotle, *Poetics* 1455 A, offers a choice between having a "special gift" or a "touch of madness."

virtuous poetry (301-308). The possession of true wisdom is the source of such poetry: first acquaint yourself with it in the writings of the Socratic school; then you'll be able to write with propriety upon suitable subjects (309-311). When you have learned from the Socratics what are the duties of man toward country, friends, family, as well as the duties of senator, judge, and general, then you can attribute the proper qualities to each character; this is the way to learn your trade and become a real imitator (312-318). A play well furnished with showy maxims and correct characters, even though not truly serious and artistic, will be more popular than pretty verses without any moral ballast (319-322).

The Greeks are real geniuses and have splendid style too, because they do not seek popularity or prettiness but glory; whereas we Romans always want to make money (323-332). Some poets desire to please and so make money, some to instruct; it is better to do both and so kill two birds (333, 334). In your teaching be not too long-winded; in your desire to please do not make up absolutely impossible stories (335-340). Our old conservatives prefer didactic poetry, our young bloods hate it; so, as I said, combine pleasure with instruction: the mark is difficult to hit, but repeated carelessness is intolerable (341-358). I bitterly regret that Homer is not quite perfect, but he must be forgiven; he wrote so much that he became fatigued (358-360). The scale of a poem is much like the scale of a picture; it may be miniature with every detail perfect, or scene-painting of which the general effect is good if you stand far enough away (361-365).¹ But, though I concede the standard of perfection depends somewhat upon the scale, nevertheless mere middling work is a sin against men and gods and the bookshops: our high poetic purpose suffers no backsliding (366-378). Yet every one, especially if well-born and well-to-do, thinks he can write poetry; to such I say — do not; but at least wait nine years before publishing, so that you may repent (379-390). For the calling of the true poet is high: witness Orpheus and Amphion, who wrought miracles; in those days poets founded civilization; Homer and Tyrtæus inspired warriors; poets taught men ethics and how to foresee the future (391-404). After the struggle of the ages men were at peace, and lyric poetry was authorized by the Muse and Apollo to charm their

¹ Cf. *περί ὕψους* 33, 4.

hard-won leisure (404-407). You must have genuine intelligence to succeed in this calling and work very hard to learn the trade (408-418).¹ You need severe masters, for if you are wealthy you are likely to be fooled by flattering critics; a true critic, such as I am, will be a regular Aristarchus to you (419-450). Let no man say it is unreasonable to be so severe about trifles, for unless you are thus severely and honestly criticized you may come to suffer from the worst of all delusions; you may think you are a good poet though absolutely untrained (450-452). In that direction lies madness: you will run about declaiming your verse to all comers, and nobody will care if you perish; none will strive officiously to keep you alive, for you kill by recitation any whom you get into your clutches (453-476).

This bald summary will suffice to show with what tenacity Horace clung to his main guiding principle, the law of literary propriety. He constantly insists upon the application of this one *arbitrium et ius et norma*.² The movement of his thought is free, precisely because it is directed from the center of Horace's mind. Yet this is the poem which Norden tries to thrust within the narrow confines of a predetermined rhetorical scheme, following the method of explanation by strangulation; this is the poem, on the other hand, which Weissenfels said "overstepped the legitimate bounds of caprice," and which is thus stigmatized by Saintsbury — "if it were not for its vividness and its constellation of glittering phrases, nobody could see in such a thing aught but a mere congeries of desultory observations."³ The constellation has not at any rate illuminated all of the commentators. Rather let us observe how each of the subsidiary doctrines enounced by Horace depends like a satellite upon the master-idea.

In the first place, the pervasive spirit of routine, the *dixeris egregie*, the faith that meter and content are fixed for all time, the treatment of character, the *rectius deducis*, the five-act and three-actor rules, all these follow by hard necessity upon the doctrine of propriety. In the second place, the excursions into literary history all serve the same end of showing what has been in the past, and come to the same conclusion that the past is the model for the future; the Greeks knew what was right, therefore the Romans must turn to the *exemplaria Graeca*.

¹ Cf. Pindar, *Ol.* 2, 86.

² *A. P.*, 72.

³ *History of Criticism*, i, p. 224.

Hence also comes the insistence upon *ars* rather than *ingenium*: for he is profoundly convinced that all the shortcomings of earlier Roman poetry and all the hasty productions of his own contemporaries are due not to any deficiency in *ingenium*, but to a deplorable lack of *ars*. Horace knows that art is long and patient of criticism, that art is respectful of precedent, conscious of a high purpose, and yet not easily puffed up. Such ideals he could not reconcile with the hurried vaudeville of Plautus, the turgid flow of Lucilius, and the roughness of all the *vetera poemata*.¹ I think that Horace has been wronged by those who represent his attitude toward the elder poets as merely a reaction against their extreme popularity and a desire to force a hearing for himself; his bitterness was really called forth by the slipshod work of his own time, and he employs the elder poets to enforce his warning.

I have spoken of the doctrine of propriety as Horace's guiding principle; but that is not the whole truth. The emphasis which Horace lays upon propriety, and the concreteness of his precepts, do not obscure the fact that propriety, the law of decorum, is only a subsidiary enactment to a greater law or set of laws. These other and paramount laws are the ideals, the criteria, the definitions of perfect form, in relation to which the law of decorum has its being. For every literary procedure, for the depiction of character and the building of plot, for each genre or *εἶδος*, there exists a distinct law of perfect form. To obey this law is propriety: to disobey is to fail utterly.² The law of decorum is therefore employed to mediate between the ideal form and its realization in practice; its function is explained at length in some passages of Cicero which I shall take up later. For example, the ideal tragedy has five acts: it is improper, if it has four or six. The ideal old man lacks enthusiasm, is dilatory, irritable, a grumbler, and a severe critic of the younger generation: to represent him as enthusiastic, prompt, kindly, is to violate the law of decorum.

Not only the *Ars Poetica* and the other literary epistles, but stray critical remarks in the rest of Horace's verse depend without exception upon the law of ideal forms and the corollary law of decorum. The epic poet may celebrate the exploits of Agrippa; not so the lyric, who

¹ Cf. *Ep.* 2, 1, 54; 2, 1, 170 ff.; and *Serm.* 1, 4, 11.

² It is perhaps necessary to say that the opinions here expressed belong to Horace: their validity will be discussed later.

is forbidden not only by modesty but by the Muse of the lyre "unapt for war" to sing of other subjects than banquets and lovers' quarrels and the affairs of a shifting heart.¹ When his Muse wanders into graver subjects, she is rebuked for her shameless insolence and bidden "quaere modos leviores plectro."² Horace reproaches Maecenas for suggesting that he sing of the wars of Rome or the mythical combats of Greece in the *molles modi* of the lyre. Again, we find a parallel to *Od.* 2, 1, in 3, 3:—

Non hoc iocosae conveniet lyrae:
quo, Musa, tendis? desine pervicax
referre sermones deorum et
magna modis tenuare parvis.

In the ninth ode of the fourth book, he tells what the lyric poet can do for Lollius; he can give him the same immortality which Pindar, Simonides, Alcaeus, Stesichorus, Anacreon and Sappho bestowed on those of whom they wrote. Finally, in *Od.* 4, 15, it is Phoebus himself who thunders the warning not to abandon lyric subjects:—

Phoebus volentem proelia me loqui
victas et urbis increpuit lyra,
ne parva Tyrrenum per aequor
vela darem . . .

In the *Epodes*, Horace refuses to finish the iambics he had begun, an *olim promissum carmen*, because he is in love, and a lover must not write iambics (*Epod.* 14).

In the first book of the *Satires*, the fourth and the tenth yield to us precepts drawn from the same central store. I have already referred to the criticism of Lucilius: Horace explains that his predecessor is at fault because he cannot endure the "laborem scribendi recte." The remedy is of course quality, not quantity; and a little later Horace thanks the gods who have made him a poet of few ideas, a poor spirit, of rare and scanty utterance!³ For these are the necessary conditions, touched with enlivening irony, of artistic production. In the same satire Horace insists that he and Lucilius are not poets, for the reason that their diction is unpoetic: and says that comedy can only be called poetry on condition that it employ heightened language. The tenth

¹ *Od.* 1, 6.

² *Od.* 2, 1, 37-40.

³ *Serm.* 1, 10, 5, 11, 69, 76.

satire contains little that is unfamiliar: one merit does not make a work of art, style must vary to suit the tone, Lucilius would write better if only he were alive now, and one must despise the applause of the vulgar. One new point, however, is well worth notice, the implied meaning of the phrase "inventore minor."¹ Horace says and sincerely believes that the inventor of a form is *ipso facto* superior to all who may come after, and thus sheds a flood of light at once upon his admission of essential inferiority in satire, and upon the proud refrain "princeps Aeolium carmen,"² "Parios ego primus iambos ostendi Latio,"³ which goes through his work like a song of triumph. I shall comment later upon the philosophical significance of the stress laid upon priority.

The *Epistles* considered apart from the *Ars Poetica* display the same tendency. Horace writes to Lollius about Homer: —

Qui quid sit pulchrum, quid turpe, quid utile, quid non,
planius ac melius Chrysippo et Crantore dicit.⁴

It is natural enough that Horace should regard the "scriptor Troiani belli" as a teacher, as a prophet, as a professor of morality; compare the passage in the *Ars* on the historical function of poetry.⁵ The nineteenth epistle contains his splendid attack upon the "imitatores, servum pecus." For the theory, his "decipit exemplar vitiis imitabile" is of a piece with his warning to unskilled imitators in the *Ars* (132); and the doctrine is the same to which Browning gave expression in his

Nokes outdares Stokes in azure feats, —
Both gorge. Who fished the murex up?
What porridge had John Keats?

In the next few lines (*Ep.* 1, 19, 21–33) Horace annihilates his detractors by asserting and defining his own title to originality. I shall quote the entire passage, for it is difficult to interpret and is apparently quite out of harmony with what he says elsewhere about the cognate problems of originality and imitation. "I have planted free steps on

¹ *Serm.* 1, 10, 48.

³ *Ep.* 1, 19, 23.

² *Od.* 3, 30, 13.

⁴ *Ep.* 1, 2, 3, 4.

⁵ Seneca, *Ep. ad Lucil.*, 88, contains similar moralizing on Homer. Le Bossu (1631–1680), and many others of his time were in substantial agreement with Horace. Cf. Julien Duchesne, *Histoire des poèmes épiques français au XVII^e siècle*, pp. 269–289.

unoccupied ground where none was before me, not trodden in the footsteps of other men. Who trusts himself will be king and leader of the swarm. I was the first to hold up to Latin eyes iambics of Paros, following the rhythms and the spirit of Archilochus, not the matter, or the language with which he hunted down Lycambes. And lest you should be inclined to decorate me with a humbler garland for fearing to change the measure and poetic form, bethink you that Sappho, no weak woman, tempers her Muse with the rhythm of Archilochus; Alcaeus tempers his; though he differs much in matter and arrangement, nor chooses a father-in-law to befoul with venomous verse, nor twists a halter for his betrothed by libellous song. He is the model, not so much as named by other tongue, whom I, the lyrist of Latium, have made known abroad: my pride is in bringing things untold before to be read by gentle eyes and held in gentle hands.”¹

First we have a straightforward declaration of primacy in the Latin imitation of Archilochus, whom he “followed in meter and in spirit”; though not in the concrete subjects of his epodes. Then he implies that some extremists have blamed him for his reluctance to alter the metrical form employed by Archilochus; a charge against which he defends himself by citing Sappho and Alcaeus, his chief exemplars in lyric poetry, who have both borrowed (at least some of) the meters of Archilochus. ‘And yet,’ Horace would say, ‘none of you my critics would dare accuse either Sappho or Alcaeus of a lack of (metrical) originality.’ According to Horace, the true test of originality for a Roman poet is not the one proposed by these extremists, i. e., the alteration of Greek metrical forms; but lies rather in the introduction of such Greek meter into Rome and strict adhesion thereto. This achievement, which seems to a modern either trivial or, at most, a subordinate part of real originality, was to the mind of Horace the primary essential. Once the meter was transferred, then and only then could Horace attend to the secondary requirement, i. e., that the matter and content (*res*) should not be too similar to the Greek original. His point of view has grown so strange that many commentators have gone astray on the lines (28, 29)

temperat Archilochi Musam pede mascula Sappho,
temperat Alcaeus, sed rebus et ordine dispar.

¹ Wickham's translation.

This has been wrongly taken to mean that "Alcaeus, though borrowing meters from Archilochus, showed his independence in everything else."¹

Such an interpretation leaves v. 28 hanging in the air; leaves it not merely unexplained, but positively detrimental to the assumed argument. For the "independence in everything else" is asserted only of Alcaeus; what then would be the use of mentioning Sappho at all? If on the other hand we adopt the interpretation I have suggested, the argument of Horace becomes reasonable; Sappho and Alcaeus are two perfect precedents, two undoubtedly original poets, who have used the meters of Archilochus little altered in form. Horace is thus clear from attack on this score, sheltered behind the Greek robes, the *exemplaria Graeca* of which he boasted. The meaning of the puzzling adversative in "sed rebus et ordine dispar" is exactly parallel to that of the negative in "non res et agentia verba Lycamben":² and the whole ideal set forth is that of the strict formal (metrical) imitation counselled in the *Ars Poetica*, modified by the warning not to imitate too closely the actual substance of the original: —

nec verbo verbum curabis reddere fidus
 interpres, nec desilies imitator in artum.³

It is not worth while to take up in detail the first two epistles of the second book. As ever, Horace castigates Roman poetry for its imperfect form, the *vestigia rursis*, and refuses even to be complimented in "prave factis versibus."⁴ His remarks on audiences and on degenerate taste recall *A. P.* 212 ff. The epistle to Florus arrests our attention by displaying a portrait very nearly related to the picture of the mad poet in the *Ars*; here we have another "scriptor delirus inersque," who is delighted with his own bad work. A second similar *motif*, that of the righteous critic, the Aristarchus of the *Ars*, is to be found in 110 ff.

We have now traversed the whole of Horace's verse in the search for his critical theory; and we have made doubly sure that the critic Horace is like one of his own ideal characters, armed cap-a-pie with consistency, *servatus ad inum qualis ab incepto processerit*. He remains

¹ Cf. Wickham, *ad loc.*

³ *A. P.* 133, 134.

² *Ep.* 1, 19, 25.

⁴ *Ep.* 2, 1, 160.

the evangelist of propriety and the high-priest of convention. His doctrine of literary forms is substantially the same as that of our modern critics, subject only to the reservation I made concerning the changes incident to progress in science and the theory of evolution. He is conspicuously lacking in speculative activity; he does not trouble himself to give the reasons and elucidate the principles which underlie his specific rules. The basis is taken for granted; he could afford to take it for granted because, as we shall see later, the fundamental axioms of his critical belief were universally accepted in his time. If his doctrine is valid, then we may logically demand that its validity be shown in his own practice, and that his artistic product correspond to his artistic principles, or rules. If on the contrary his doctrine is not valid for his own work, if it can be proved that the practising artist quietly foreswore or ignored the body of rules which he himself laid down, then I shall maintain that we have absolutely conclusive evidence of its essential falsity. For a theory which pretends to lay down the laws of poetry must stand or fall by one test and only one test, the facts in the case. Either meter and content are inseparably connected, or else the laws are void and of no effect.

These laws are most distinctly stated in *Ars Poetica* 73-98. They may be recapitulated as follows: (1) the feats of kings and captains and war's sad tale must be written in hexameter, (2) the voice of complaint and of granted prayers in pentameter, (3) anger, as well as comedy and tragedy, in the iambus, (4) gods, children of gods, the victor in boxing and the horse first in the race, the troubles of young hearts and the gay banquet, in lyric meters. One subdivision of the third law requires that the verses and diction of comedy be distinguished from the verses and diction of tragedy. One subdivision of the first law permits hexameter to be employed for the *sermo* or satire, by the authority of the inventor Lucilius; but we have the express statement of Horace that the *sermo* is not poetry, so that this subdivision is nominal and not real. Such then is the tenor of the laws. Let us look to his poems for the practice.

The law demands that there be no mixture of genres; that the subjects of epic, of lyric, of iambic, of satire, be kept in separate metrical compartments. If we discover that Horace deals with the same theme in both iambic and lyric meters, or if the *Epodes* are not all angry, the

law is void, at least so far as Horace is concerned. The only use that a critic has for a law of poetry is instrumental; i. e., if the law is valid, he may confidently employ it as a tool to explain poetry which has been written by poets themselves under the dominion of that law. But if the poet did not obey the 'law,' the critic is thereby forced to abandon it as a defective instrument. He has no choice; if he attempts to retain the invalid law, he is no longer a critic, but a false substitute for the original poet; he will either try to re-write the original poem in conformity with the imaginary law (as Ribbeck and countless others have done), or he will *vi et armis* insert the law into his interpretation of the poem (as Norden did).

Let us assume that Horace has succeeded in realizing the first part of his boast, in the adaptation to Latin of the metrical form of his avowed master Archilochus; has he been equally successful in the second part, in the reincarnation of that bitter spirit, the *ira* which has immortalized the poet and eternally disgraced the man? Our answer must be in the negative. Out of the seventeen epodes, only nine can be said to display the Archilochian spirit. The other eight are not only not satirical, but are demonstrably lyric in feeling and content. Let us first examine the Archilochian nine. The third, fourth, fifth, sixth, eighth, tenth, twelfth and seventeenth epodes are satirical enough to leave no doubt of their classification. The second epode is more puzzling; sixty-six lines of genuine lyric beauty are so to speak upset by the four lines at the close. Can the addition of these four lines be fairly said to transmute the whole poem into a satire? The true explanation is to be found, as Sellar has shown, in the character of Horace: who, "when he is most in earnest, checks himself and brings himself back to the ordinary mood in which he meets society."¹ The procedure is familiar to us from the *Odes*,² and is also exemplified by his ironical qualification of the wise man, "praecipue sanus, nisi cum pituita molesta est."³ The closest analogies to this epode are to be found in the *Georgics* of Virgil and the *Elegies* of Tibullus; in spite of the fact that neither Virgil nor Tibullus wrote in Parian iambs. Therefore the best of all the epodes is too idiosyncratic to admit of classification.

¹ Sellar, *Horace and the Elegiac Poets*, p. 130.

² *Od.* 2, 1, 37-40; 3, 3, 69-72.

³ *Ep.* 1, 1, 108.

The other eight epodes are in tone indistinguishable from the *Odes*. The first epode is no less lyric than *Od.* 2, 6; 2, 7; 2, 17; the seventh, ninth and sixteenth present the most instructive similarities with the political odes.¹ The eleventh is made up of commonplaces on love; the *limina dura* and the *latus* play the same rôle as in *Od.* 3, 10 and in a host of elegies, comedies and epigrams.² The thirteenth closely resembles *Od.* 1, 9; the fourteenth contains a familiar confession

. . . me libertina neque uno
contenta Phryne macerat;

and the fifteenth is the rejected lover's complaint.³

The 'law of wrath' is therefore so far from being valid for the *Epodes* that only a bare majority of them are in various degrees explicable by its terms. In other words, it is impossible for a critic acquainted with this so-called law to predict, before reading a given epode, what the general character of that epode will be. The conclusion is inevitable that the poet Horace was not governed by the law of the iambic genre which he himself stated; as for the critical consequences of this conclusion, they will be discussed after the *Odes* have been examined.

At this point, I am overtaken by a natural scruple; the words of Martial creep into my mind — "improbe facit, qui in alieno libro ingeniosus est." It may be destructive of the spirit to pursue the same method of analysis on the precious body of the *Carmina* which I have already employed in the minor case of the *Epodes*. Nevertheless, it must be done; first, proof must be given that a large number of the odes cannot be classified according to the laws of the lyric genre. There are at least two ways in which this may be accomplished: either by showing that the content of a given poem differs from all the contents sanctified by law, or by showing that the content of a given poem would fairly entitle us to classify it under a different genre. After it has been proved that the laws are inoperative and are as empty of

¹ Plüss, followed by Sellar, regards the ninth epode as an Archilochian invective "against the foreign queen." He asserts that vv. 23-26 refer to Cleopatra, Jugurtha and Hasdrubal. There is nothing in the Latin to justify or even suggest this interpretation; it is merely one more instance of the mania which forces poems to be misread by their labels.

² Cf. *Ov. Am.* 1, 9, 19; *Lucret.* 4, 1177; and *Od.* 1, 25. ³ Cf. *Od.* 1, 6, 13.

reality in this case as in that of the *Epodes*, then I shall try to make amends to the spirit of Horace by a brief sketch of what I believe to have been his actual procedure in lyric composition.

In the first place, we discover that two odes violate by their metrical structure the boundary between ode and epode; they use the Alcmanian strophe in common with the twelfth epode.¹ The infrequency of this violation renders it of no great consequence; but it shows at any rate that Horace did not hesitate, after composing three poems identical in form, to publish two as lyrics and the other as an epode.² Much more urgent is the problem of the classification of the odes according to content; if all of them deal with consecrated lyric subjects handled in lyric form, the law is valid. I shall mention only those cases which constitute a definite departure from the terms of the law.

In the first book of the *Odes*, *Pastor cum traheret* (15) is essentially epic, *Quis desiderio* (24) is elegiac, *Parcius iunctas* (25) is satiric, *Te maris et terrae* (28) is dramatic elegy, *Icci, beatiss* (29) is epigrammatic. In the second book, *Ulla si iuris* (8) is undoubted satire; in the third, *Donec gratus eram* (9) is clearly dramatic, *Extremum Tanain* (10) is erotic elegy or else an epigram, *Uxor pauperis Ibyci* (15) and in the fourth book *Audivere Lyce* (13) are satirical. It is obvious that Horace, the perfect artist, was a desperate mixer of genres; for the laws of lyric precedent certainly do not cover the odes just cited. But suppose that some defender of these laws be confronted with poems which cannot by any extension of fancy be identified with any previously existing genre of lyric, or with any mixture of genres: with poems which are a genuine new creation on the part of Horace: he will then be compelled to admit that his position is untenable. For he cannot make any new category for an ode of Horace without flying in the face of Horace's energetic denunciation in the *Ars*, 86-88: —

descriptas servare vices operumque colores
cur ego si nequeo ignoroque poeta salutor ?
cur nescire pudens prave quam discere malo ?

Yet it is precisely such a new creation which we cannot avoid recognizing in the larger and better portion of the odes, in those very poems

¹ *Od.* I, 7 and 28.

² I do not mean to imply that these three poems were composed and published at about the same time. The epode is probably earlier than the two odes.

which guarantee the immortality of Horace and secure for him the title of poet. I mean, of course, the odes in which he embodied his patriotism and his morality in verses of undeniable originality. What work, out of all which were written previous to the time of Horace, can be cited as precedent for *Iam satis terris* (1, 2), for *Motum ex Metello* (2, 1), for *Iam pauca aratro* (2, 15), for the glorious sequence which opens the third book, for *Qualem ministrum* (4, 4) and *Divis orte bonis* (4, 5), for *Quae cura patrum* (4, 14) and *Phoebus volentem* (4, 15)? "None but a Roman could have conceived them: none among all the Romans but Horace could have written them." The same is true of his moralizing odes; they contain many a commonplace idea, which might have been expressed in almost any literary form, but they come to us with the unmistakable stamp of his style and his genius. A great number of the best odes are therefore refractory to classification; and the laws of the lyric genre upheld by Horace the critic are definitely annulled by Horace the poet. The argument is logically complete and might be left at this point; but it will be profitable to look at the other side of the shield and inquire what, if any, odes are after all susceptible of regular labels.

On reading through the odes, we find that many of them can be arranged under two such labels; (1) those in praise of the gods, (2) those which describe *iuvenum curas*, love-affairs. Under the first head fall 1, 10, 12, 18, 21, 30, 34, 35; 2, 19; 3, 11, 18, 25; 4, 1, 3: under the second, 1, 5, 8, 13, 19, 22, 23, 27; 2, 4, 5, 12; 3, 7, 9, 10, 20, 26, 28; 4, 10, 11. Now these are for the most part correctly and prettily turned verses, *amabilia carmina*; some of them deserve to be called charming; but be it said at once that with rare exceptions they are the least vital and the least inspired work that Horace has left us. How could it be otherwise? Horace did not believe in the gods; Horace was not an ardent lover. Bacchus¹ is not a real deity to him, but a name conventionally equivalent to "wine" or to "poetical inspiration"; and the strife of commentators in the vain endeavor to decide which of Horace's loves was the least unreal is sufficient evidence that his love-poems are decorative but not heartfelt. They might, to paraphrase Wordsworth, be defined as "Alcaeus recollected in tranquillity." Horace wrote poems to the gods because it suited the formal religious revival of his

¹ *Od.* 3, 25.

epoch; he wrote verses on love because it was a popular theme and also because the Greek lyric poets had done so before him. As for his poems in praise of wine, they are undoubtedly more sincere; though they are never touched with the earnestness of our old song "Back and side go bare, go bare."

We may therefore conclude not only that the generic laws are inapplicable to the *Odes* taken as a whole, but also that even in the cases where the laws appear valid *their validity is in inverse ratio to the originality and personal merit of the poems*. I suspect that our haste to revolt against romanticism, against extravagant and unbalanced expression, has led many students of the classics to tumble into the opposite abyss, and to praise classical poets for their supposed obedience to rules which had they really been obeyed would have destroyed poetry as surely as a mechanical organ destroys music. F. W. H. Myers, in his essay on Wordsworth, deals wisely with Wordsworth's own attempt to construct a theory of poetry. "Poetry, like all the arts, is essentially a mystery. Its charm depends upon qualities which we can neither define accurately, nor reduce to rule, nor create again at pleasure. Mankind, however, are unwilling to admit this; and they endeavor from time to time to persuade themselves that they have discovered the rules which will enable them to produce the desired effect. Among such incomplete explanations Wordsworth's essays must certainly be ranked. It would not be safe for any man to believe that he had produced true poetry because he had fulfilled the conditions which Wordsworth lays down." In the same way we may affirm that if Horace had complied with his own rules, he would not have been the Horace we know and love, but a mere poetaster.

Are we then left rudderless, to drift without any positive guidance, without any hope of understanding the actual procedure of Horace? Let us consider his practice by itself, and try to penetrate some little distance beneath the surface of that most difficult of all mysteries, the mystery of creation. It is clear enough now that we can never hope to reach the truth by the aid of the doctrine of literary genres, which, like Milton's oracle, runs through the archèd roof of the palace of literature in words deceiving. No critic, however profoundly versed in the lyrics which had been written *ante Horatium*, could have predicted the scope and content of the body of poetry left us by Horace. So long as we had

faith in the rules, it was comparatively easy to explain an ode. All we had to do was to discover in what meter it was written, and to classify it with the other poems written in the same meter; genus *lyric*, species *Sapphic*, content *light, graceful and rapid, expressive either of gay or serious animation of feeling*.¹ To abandon the rules is to undertake a harder and (I must insist) a more valuable kind of criticism; we are brought face to face with the personality of Horace. He is not easy to understand, for no man of genius is easy to understand; a complete explanation is impossible, but that does not excuse us from making a beginning.

Fortunately Horace has not left us without guidance. For the *Ars Poetica* is not merely an exposition of general critical theory, but also the most minute description of the actual task of composition. In it the poet tells us frankly how he wrote his lyrics. Ostensibly the *Ars* is largely devoted to laying down rules for the construction of comedy and tragedy; but it is of far greater actual value as a self-revelation, which enables us to follow the poet into his very sanctuary. This statement seems to contradict what has been said above concerning the proved discrepancy between the theory and the practice of Horace, but the contradiction is only apparent; for previously we were discussing the theory of literary genres, whereas now I refer to those passages which relate to the choice of words and phrases, to the slow torture of the pen. The portrait of the good critic, the Aristarchus who "if verses are dull will point it out; if they are harsh in rhythm, will find fault with them; if they are rough in style, will make an ugly cross with black ink opposite to them; who will apply the knife to redundant ornament; who will bid you clear up ambiguities and will mark what should be changed" — this portrait is sheer autobiography. The identity is established by Horace himself in the famous lines

ego apis Matinae
more modoque
grata carpentis thyma per laborem
plurimum circa nemus uvidique
Tiburis ripas operosa parvus
carmina fingo.²

¹ Sellar, *op. cit.*, pp. 186 ff. Sellar's attempts to discriminate between Sapphic and Alcaic odes are utterly untenable.

² *Od.* 4, 2, 27-32.

To build an ode line upon line, strophe upon strophe, fitting, joining, struggling with the limited Latin stock of words until he had attained formal and detailed perfection, the neatness of incision for which a lapidary strives, — that was Horace's way. Petronius put the truth in two words; his *curiosa felicitas* (the laborious art of making phrases) is far better criticism than Quintilian's *verbis felicissime audax*. Hence the obvious insincerity of those verses in which Horace claims to be drunk with inspiration; his chosen companion was the file and not the bottle, Aristarchus and not Bacchus.¹

But Horace, like every other man, was subject to the defects of his qualities; his self-confessed attention to detail led him to forget the whole while he was engaged on the parts, and thus constantly to break one of his own maxims.² Take this tendency along with his personal and racial dislike of thinking a subject through, and I believe we have the explanation of many a puzzling poem, both in the *Sermones* and in the *Odes*. For example in *Od.* 1, 3, the first eight verses pray for the safety of Virgil in his voyage to Greece; the remainder of the poem insists vigorously upon the impiety and peril of attempting to sail the "estranging sea." Surely this is to set a human head upon the neck of a horse; the structure is utterly illogical. Logic is indeed of no avail before such a difficulty; but the mental habits of Horace, which were not logical, forced him to work slowly and to think not by units but by fractions. His original impulse to write a courteous *bon voyage* to Virgil endured for the space of eight lines; but that, Horace felt, was insufficient. He had to go on, though he had said all he had to say to Virgil; so he drew upon his inexhaustible store of commonplace, from the particular compartment which dealt with ships and sailors.³ Meantime Virgil was forgotten, and soon the forty lines of Asclepiads were brought to a triumphant conclusion. Yet the conclusion had no more and no less to do with the beginning than the end of a train of thought has to do with the beginning.

Another instance is *Laudabunt alii*, of which the first fourteen verses are a rhetorical celebration of Tibur, the following six advise Plancus to "finire tristitiam vitaeque labores molli mero," and the last twelve

¹ Cf. *Od.* 3, 25.

² *A. P.*, 25, 34, 35.

³ Cf. K. F. Smith's edition of Tibullus, pp. 244-247, for parallels; the idea is "largely due to the Cynics and Stoics."

adduce the precedent of Teucer.¹ The *vera causa* of this disjointed composition is the mental habit of the composer, whose attention was concentrated upon the task of writing Alcmanian strophes, upon the unity of meter; while the unity of thought and central purpose was unheeded.

Turn to *Vides ut alta stet*; in the first few lines a picture of extreme cold weather is succeeded by the sage counsel

nec dulcis amores
sperne puer neque tu choreas,
donec virenti canities abest
morosa.²

By this time the stage-setting of the poem has wholly slipped the attention of the poet, who concludes

nunc et campus et areae
lenesque sub noctem susurri
composita repetantur hora,
nunc et latentis proditor intimo
gratus puellae risus ab angulo
pignusque dereptum lacertis
aut digito male pertinaci.³

Everyone knows that the dead of winter at Rome is hardly the season for the "campus et areae" and "lenes sub noctem susurri."

At this point I must enter a *caveat*. Some one may fancy that I am endeavoring to exhibit defects in these odes which we all love, to indicate the presence of imperfections which should lead us to condemn; on the contrary, I feel that Horace becomes more human and more sympathetic just in the degree that his poetry is a revelation of his character and his ways. It was the settled practice of the Renaissance that classical poetry should be regarded as the achievement of objective perfection; a practice which has had the most disastrous consequences. The very name of the 'humanities' forbids that they be tried by the criterion of impeccability. In other words, the meteorology of Horace is totally indifferent to the critic of literature, save in so far as the

¹ *Od.* i, 7.

² *Od.* i, 9.

³ It is almost certain that *nunc* means "while you are young" as well as "now"; but, however it be taken, it contains no reference to the open fire and the wine.

personality of Horace was affected by his scientific beliefs. If a poem were a machine, then we should be justified in applying to it the tests we employ with machinery; accuracy to fact, conformance to objective reality, and efficiency. But a genuine poem is not a machine, and is always subjective. Let me give a few more examples.

Integer vitae has long been felt to present difficulties. It begins like a hymn with the more or less solemn proclamation of the poet's inviolability, and ends with the gaiety of

dulce ridentem Lalagen amabo,
dulce loquentem.

Now that we are rid of the old deceptive tenet that poems are written according to a predetermined scheme, it is not hard to imagine how the poem grew. The first eight verses are on a theme present in many of his odes; "di me tuentur, dis pietas mea et musa cordi est."¹ After he had composed these verses, it occurred to him that he might continue with one of the illustrative anecdotes of which he was so fond.² The mention of Lalage in v. 10 is a purely decorative detail, appropriate to the theme. Had the ode ended with v. 16, it would indeed have been logically complete, though not half so good a poem. But Horace was not yet satisfied; his mind recurred to Lalage and made her furnish him with a conclusion which was far from being implied in the ironical address to Fuscus. The same habit of psychological transition may be observed in *Parcus deorum cultor*,³ where Jupiter is displaced five lines before the end by the goddess Fortuna; in *Mercuri — nam te*,⁴ where Lyde is quite forgotten at the close of the poem; in *Impios parrae*,⁵ where Galatea suffers the same fate as Lyde; and in *Tyrrhena regum*,⁶ where Maecenas suffers the same fate as Galatea.

Every man who knows Horace must make his own reconstruction of the *Odes*, and it is not at all my intention to attribute to the preceding paragraphs the sort of scientific validity which belongs to a mathematical demonstration, or to deny the value of interpretations written from another point of view. Genius, because it is alive, is always changing; and the trait of Horace's character which I have tried to

¹ *Od.* 1, 17, 13; 1, 26, 1; 2, 7, 12; 3, 4, 25-36. Cf. Ovid, *Ars Amat.* 3, 548-550; *Fasti* 6, 20.

² Cf. *Od.* 2, 7, 13; 3, 4, *passim*; *Serm.* 2, 3, 142-157; 2, 6, 79-117; 2, 8, 54-78.

³ *Od.* 1, 34.

⁴ *Od.* 3, 11.

⁵ *Od.* 3, 27.

⁶ *Od.* 3, 29.

indicate above was not permanently in the foreground of his writing. When he was inspired by a strong and durable emotion, Horace composed poems which are all one piece of "linked sweetness." The thought of death was often with him, and enabled him to write *Eheu fugaces*,¹ *Postume*; he loved Maecenas, and we have *Cur me querelis*;² he warmly admired Augustus, as well as the peace and safety of which Augustus was the symbol, and we have *Divis orte bonis*.³ These poems, and others such as these, betray no faltering, no change of theme; the current of his inspiration was not at any point interrupted or broken. In other words, we have ample proof that Horace frequently surpassed his ordinary self: which is the most disconcerting and precious quality of genius.

We have seen that the rules promulgated by Horace the critic do not hold when compared with the positive practice of the poet; that the law of literary genres is not a valid criterion in the case of that author who has so long been cited as one of its chief supporters, and that his doctrine did not determine his action. It is legitimate to infer that such critical theories are in need of close examination on the historical side. For their influence in ancient and modern times has been vast and their dominion over the realm of classical criticism has been practically unquestioned. If then it be possible to understand their genesis in antiquity, we shall arrive at a more accurate appraisal of their worth. If it become plain that they had their origin in confusion and in error, we shall be in a better position to judge the course of subsequent literary history, and we may be able to approach the solution of other and weightier problems than that presented by the *Ars Poetica*.

The *Ars Poetica* is not an isolated phenomenon. It is surrounded by a cloud of witnesses, chief among which are the rhetorical works of Cicero. I shall not attempt to deal with Varro and Lucilius, because I wish to avoid conjectural restorations, and because Cicero will furnish us with ample evidence for the purposes of the present argument. It is a noteworthy fact that Cicero's conception of eloquence corresponds very closely to the Horatian conception of poetry, and that an identical theory lies at the foundation of their critical precepts. Cicero will also do us the invaluable service of revealing the *fons et origo*, the great common source upon which they both drew.

¹ *Od.* 2, 14.² *Od.* 2, 17.³ *Od.* 4, 5.

Like poetry, *eloquentia* has a glorious origin, "id ex honestissimis causis atque optimis rationibus profectum";¹ eloquence broke through the "crust of custom" and instituted new and better ways of living; turned men from violence to justice, and gradually civilized the world.² Cicero ventures even to claim for eloquence that merit which was supreme at Rome: "tantam vim habet illa, quae recte a bono poeta dicta est 'flexanima atque omnium regina rerum oratio,' ut non modo inclinantem excipere aut stantem inclinare, sed etiam adversantem ac repugnantem *ut imperator fortis ac bonus* capere possit."³

The end and aim of eloquence, like that of poetry, is to instruct, to give pleasure, to stir to action;⁴ Cicero avoids the old problem of the morality of rhetoric by insisting that the true orator must be virtuous, that *sapientia* must be united to the power of speech.⁵ The utmost stress is laid upon the necessity of "locutio emendata et Latina";⁶ *natura* and *ars* are frequently discussed, quite in the Horatian manner and with the same conclusion; and the difficulty of the orator's task is urged throughout, just as Horace dwells upon the indispensable *limae labor*.⁷

Much could be made of these and other coincidences of doctrine; but they are not so important as the underlying theory of which they are the expression. This theory is lucidly stated in the *Orator*, 70-75, and it deserves to be quoted at length; for in this passage Cicero emphasizes the mediating function of the doctrine of decorum to which reference was made *supra* p. 22: — "The perfect orator . . . will be able to speak in whatever style the case may demand. Now wisdom is the basis of eloquence as it is of everything else; for it is a task of the

¹ *De inv.* 1, 2.

² *De inv.* 1, 2 and 3.

³ *De Or.* 2, 187; cf. *Brutus*, 256: "multo magnus orator praestat minutis imperatoribus."

⁴ *Brutus*, 185; *A. P.*, 343, 344.

⁵ It is interesting to compare this with Aristotle, *Rhet.*, 1, 1. Aristotle like Cicero admits that rhetoric can be abused, but says: τοῦτό γε κοινόν ἐστι κατὰ πάντων τῶν ἀγαθῶν πλὴν ἀρετῆς, and that truth is more easy to prove than error. Cicero has simply taken the step logically indicated by Aristotle, and defines eloquence as *sapientia* + rhetoric. In the *de Part. Or.* 1, 2, he is giving the rules of mere rhetoric and therefore says nothing of *sapientia*. Cf. *de Or.* 3, 55.

⁶ *Brutus*, 258; *de Or.* 3, 38.

⁷ *De Or.* 1, 109; 1, 223; 2, 5; 3, 22; *Brutus*, 25.

utmost difficulty to perceive what is fitting, in speech no less than in life. The Greeks call this *πρέπον*; we may use the word *decorum*. Not only has a great deal been written on this topic, but it is in the highest degree worthy of our study; for ignorance of decorum is the cause not only of faults in daily life, but is the principal source of faulty poems and speeches. The orator must moreover observe propriety not alone in the substance of his discourse but also in its verbal expression; for both the expression and the substance must be varied according to considerations of fortune, office, influence, age, place, time and hearer. Always, in every part of a speech, as in every part of life, we must heed the requirements of propriety. Propriety depends upon the subject under discussion, and upon the characters both of those who speak and of those who are addressed; it is a topic of great scope and range, and is therefore handled *by philosophers in ethical treatises, by grammarians writing on poetry, and by orators in every kind and subdivision of their subject*. For surely propriety is violated, if you employ on a single judge the most eloquent phrases and lofty *loci communes* to plead a petty case of damages caused by rain; or if, when the majesty of the Roman people is at stake, your speech be mean and pettifogging. . . . On every occasion you must watch to see how far you may go; for though every man has his own limit, it is better to err by falling short rather than by going too far. . . . Since we must avail ourselves of this principle of decorum in all we say or do, be it little or great; since it is plain that this principle is of vast importance and of the widest applicability (though it depends upon other considerations than those which govern duty, for duty signifies the fulfilment of obligations which rest always upon us all, whereas decorum varies according to occasion and to character); since the force of decorum is manifest not only in what we do and say, but also in facial expression, in our bearing and gait; if breaches in decorum are equally manifest and are avoided by poets as the worst of blemishes, as for example when a poet represents a base man speaking uprightly, or a fool wisely; if that famous painter was aware, in depicting the sacrifice of Iphigenia, whereat Calchas was sad, Ulysses deeply affected, Menelaus filled with grief, that he must draw Agamemnon as having his head covered, since no brush could imitate that supreme sorrow; if finally even an actor must aim at propriety; what shall we say of the orator ?

Since the power of propriety is so great, the orator will pay attention thereto in every case and every part of a case; for it is clear that not only the lesser parts of a speech but each oration by itself ought to be *fashioned after a different model. We must therefore discover the characteristic mark and form which belongs to every kind.*"

"Sequitur, ut cuiusque generis nota quaeratur et formula"; these words are the key to the doctrine of decorum, for they reveal the standard, the criterion by which propriety must in each case be tested. By following the clue they afford, we may hope to arrive at a fairly clear notion of the philosophical basis of Cicero's rhetorical compositions; which will in turn serve to explain the poetical theories of Horace. Perhaps the best method will be to examine the *Orator*, its purpose and its argument; for the account of his position given in the *Orator* is of necessity more direct and less hedged about by qualifications than in the dialogue of the *De Oratore*.

In the first place, his purpose is to shadow forth the shape and image of perfect eloquence,¹ to express an unrealized and unrealizable ideal,² to tell what is the best *genus orationis*;³ he repeatedly employs the words *species* and *forma* as synonymous with *optimum genus*. This last term has such a wide range of meaning that we might not be certain of its equivalence in this passage, were it not for two references in his letters, which give to the *Orator* the title "*de optimo genere dicendi*."⁴ Our next step must be to determine what Cicero meant by these terms *species* and *forma*. Fortunately he gives us an explicit definition. Phidias (he says), when sculpturing a statue of Jupiter or of Minerva, was not copying an actual model, but had in his mind a *species pulchritudinis eximia quaedam, quam intuens in eaque defixus ad illius similitudinem artem et manum dirigebat*. In like manner we may form a conception of perfect eloquence, an inner vision which corresponds to the inner vision of Phidias: — "*ut igitur in formis et figuris est aliquid perfectum et excellens, cuius ad cogitatam speciem referuntur ea, quae sub oculos ipsa cadunt, sic perfectae eloquentiae speciem animo videmus, effigiem auribus quaerimus.*"⁵ In the next sections Cicero makes a statement which is not only decisive of the philosophical source of his method, but which will also enable us to explain the genesis of the

¹ *Or.* 43.² *Or.* 7, 8.³ *Or.* 52.⁴ *Ep. ad Fam.* 12, 17, 2; *ad Att.* 14, 20, 3.⁵ *Or.* 9.

doctrine of decorum and of ideal forms of literature as held by Cicero, by Horace, and so far as we know by all the critics of their time: ¹ — “Has rerum formas appellat *idēas* ille non intellegendi solum, sed etiam *dicendi gravissimus auctor et magister Plato*, easque gigni negat et ait semper esse ac ratione et intelligentia contineri; cetera nasci, occidere, fluere, labi, nec diutius esse uno et eodem statu. quicquid est igitur, de quo ratione et via disputetur, id est ad ultimam sui generis formam speciemque redigendum. ac video hanc primam ingressionem meam non ex oratoriis disputationibus ductam, sed e media philosophia repetitam et ea quidem cum antiqua tum subobscura aut reprehensionis aliquid aut certe admirationis habituram: nam aut mirabuntur quid haec pertineant ad ea, quae quaerimus; quibus satisfaciet res ipsa cognita, ut non sine causa alte repetita videatur, aut reprehendent, quod inusitatas vias indagemus, tritas relinquamus. ego autem et me saepe nova videri dicere intellego, cum pervetera dicam, sed inaudita plerisque, et fateor me oratorem, si modo sim aut etiam quicumque sim, non ex rhetorum officinis, sed *ex Academiae spatiis exstitisse*; illa enim sunt curricula multiplicium variorumque sermonum; sed et huius et aliorum philosophorum disputationibus et exagitatus maxime orator est et adiutus: omnis enim ubertas et quasi silva dicendi ducta ab illis est nec satis tamen instructa ad forensis causas; quas, ut illi ipsi dicere solebant, agrestioribus Musis reliquerunt.”

It is manifest therefore that Cicero's ideal orator is to be constructed by systematic reasoning upon the model of a Platonic ‘ideal’; that he has chosen not to continue the ordinary rhetorical discussions but to have direct recourse to philosophy; that he anticipates censure and surprise will be caused by his unconventional procedure. But in reality his critics will merely reveal their own lack of familiarity with the previous history of thought, for he will appear unconventional only to those who work in the rhetoric-shops, and not to those who have dwelt in the Academy.

One would think that this was a sufficiently explicit statement of the source from which Cicero drew his doctrine of an ideal form of eloquence; and yet modern criticism has paid little or no attention either to the statement itself or to its consequences. Laurand, after quoting

¹ Or. 10-12.

this very passage from the *Orator*, says “Cicero, *therefore*, did not borrow from Plato much which has to do with the art of oratory.”¹ This is an astounding sample of the art of “Quellenforschung” as it is practised today. To say that Cicero did not borrow much from Plato, when Cicero has just admitted or rather boasted that his whole doctrine of an ideal form of eloquence is due to Plato! It cannot be said too emphatically that such a system of Quellenforschung serves only to obscure the truth. The sole method of imitation which it takes into account is imitation by quotation, the mechanical reproduction of words and phrases; while it suffers the essential relationship of one thinker with another to go unheeded.

Leaving Plato for a moment, let us go back to Cicero and Horace. Cicero has said that the *species* and *forma*, the *optimum genus* of eloquence, is a Platonic idea. A difficulty at once arises out of the very definition of the *ἰδέα*. How can that which is eternal, which neither is born nor perishes, which is always the same, — how can such an ideal be adapted to the practical uses of oratory, to the infinite flux and change of daily life, to the exigencies of circumstance? Yet the solution is apparently very simple, and we have it in Cicero’s own words: — “is erit enim eloquens, qui et humilia subtiliter et magna graviter et mediocria temperate potest dicere.”² All eloquence has been divided into three parts or styles; perfect eloquence therefore consists in mastery of each of these three and in the ability to employ each at the proper time. It is no longer static and fixed; it has been dowered with life and flexibility by means of the doctrine of decorum. Without the aid of τὸ πρέπον, the antinomy could not be resolved, no rules could be laid down; without its aid, no art of rhetoric could be written and no art of rhetoric was written.³ It is the doctrine of decorum that mediates between the ideal form of eloquence and the practice of oratory, in

¹ *De Tull. Ciceronis studiis rhetoricis*, p. 25.

² *Or.* 100.

³ I have not sufficient space to go into this in detail; but it is quite certainly true. Both Quintilian and Dionysius of Halicarnassus (to name only two witnesses) maintain the supreme importance of decorum. Cf. Dion. Hal. *de comp. verb.* 20: καὶ γὰρ τοῖς ἄλλοις χρώμασιν ἀπασὶ παρέῖναι δεῖ τὸ πρέπον. καὶ εἰ τι ἄλλο ἔργον ἀτυχεῖ τούτου τοῦ μέρους, καὶ εἰ μὴ τοῦ παντός, τοῦ κρατίστου γε ἀτυχεῖ. Quin. 11, 1, 1: “proxima est cura, ut dicamus *apte*; quam virtutem quartam elocutionis Cicero demonstrat, quaeque est meo quidem iudicio maxime necessaria.”

precisely the same manner that it mediates between the several ideal forms of poetry and the practice of poetical composition. Cicero has proclaimed that Plato is his master: Horace, too, has told us that the *Socraticae chartae* are the source of all good poetry.

We are now in a position to assert the fundamental identity of the critical theory of Cicero and of Horace. Each maintains the same doctrine of decorum as the basis of judgment upon any literary performance; each establishes a fixed literary ideal as the criterion in relation to which decorum must be measured. We have seen that these two doctrines underlie all their critical utterances and are the framework upon which both writers build. Furthermore, we have Cicero's word for it that Plato is the source of the doctrine of an ideal form of eloquence; a fact which would be obvious even if Cicero had not called our attention to it. Up to this point, we have reached certain definite results; it will be profitable to sum them up before taking the next step.

We began with an examination of the doctrine of literary forms as it has been applied to the criticism of the *Ars Poetica*; we discovered that it produced confusion and disagreement; we then studied the doctrine as promulgated by Horace and found that it did not avail to explain his own poetry. We then undertook to trace the genealogy of this doctrine and its corollary, the doctrine of propriety; and we learn from Cicero not only that they permeate his rhetorical writings but also that they have been borrowed from Plato. We have already given serious grounds for the belief that the doctrine of literary forms is not sound. So far as critics trust themselves to it, they are betrayed into externality, into prolonged examination of the outer features and into wrangling over classifications; while the individual and personal, the heart and soul of the truth, are left severely alone, or are dismissed briefly as mere aesthetic trifles. Is it conceivable that Plato is responsible for this erroneous method of literary criticism? Has Cicero any justification for attributing his scheme of eloquence to the great philosopher?

I believe that Cicero is right, and that Plato is responsible; and I shall devote the last part of this paper to a discussion of causes and consequences. We must attack the error at its source, which is the doctrine of ideas; for the laws of the genres are nothing but the expression in the sphere of literature of the Platonic doctrine of ideal forms.

The Platonic doctrine is, I believe, logically inapplicable to literature; yet Plato sought so to apply it, and the results have been disastrous for all his followers, from Aristotle and Horace to Brunetière and Norden, as well as for Plato himself. The historical process has been long and infinitely complex; our only chance of understanding it depends upon our ability to sympathize with Plato and interpret his purposes, without being swallowed by him. For his magic is so strong, his charms so powerful, that it is hard to read him without being overwhelmed by them; of all the arts that he learned from his master Socrates, the art of making disciples was the one he acquired most thoroughly.

Now it was the purpose of Plato to enthrone scientific truth, and to establish its dominion over the universe by means of dialectic.¹ He searched for the reality which underlies all appearance, for an abiding identity somewhere apart from the multitude of phenomena. He knew that poetry is vastly different from scientific truth; therefore he excluded poetry from his ideal state. Grant his premises, and you are compelled to grant his conclusion; but the premises are absolutely false. Intense as may be our admiration for Plato, it must not blind us to the fact that there is something fatally wrong in a theory of art which annihilates Homer. Παλαιά τις διαφορά φιλοσοφία τε καὶ ποιητικῇ: old is the quarrel between poetry and philosophy, says Plato in an apologetic passage.² If this quarrel can be resolved, no matter how tentatively and imperfectly, we shall have gone far on the road to an understanding of the bold position of Plato. First we must define. Philosophy means to Plato the search for those eternal natures which constitute the inner reality of the universe, and which alone can be objects of true knowledge.³ Once they are discovered, he intends to make the world over upon their model. Their truth is unalterable; they remain the same from everlasting to everlasting. Precisely in this respect, that is in their permanence and their uniformity, resides the essential likeness between the modern scientist's "laws of nature" and the Platonic ideas; there are of course differences between the two conceptions, but the fundamental postulate, the postulate of uniformity, remains the same. Without this postulate, modern science is

¹ I use the term "scientific," because science means to most of us now the same thing that philosophy meant to Plato; knowledge which is certain and is free from self-contradiction.

² *Rep.* 607.

³ Cf. C. C. J. Webb, *History of Philosophy*, p. 32.

unthinkable; and it is from this point of view that Plato's truth can rightly be called scientific. Both the modern scientist and Plato assume that the laws of nature are incapable of change. But poetry is a very different thing; in the widest sense of the word, poetry is an expression of man's creative power, of man's indefeasible and divine gift of altering the universe and of bringing into being something that never was before. Here then we have two undeniable facts; poetry on the one side and science on the other. If we can discern just what these contrasted realities mean to man, what relation they bear to human life, we shall also be able to draw some inferences concerning the relation of the Platonic ideas to human life.

The laws of nature are unalterable; in so far as we have to do with them, we are in unqualified subjection to them. When we speak of man's conquest of nature, we do not mean that these laws have been transformed by man, but merely that increasing knowledge of them has enabled us to avail ourselves of principles imperfectly known hitherto. Science lays down rules which men must obey; and strict obedience to these rules is a guarantee of perfect success, or rather of success which is perfect within certain limits and in certain ways. To forget the limitations of science is literally a fatal error, an error which brings death with it; for it does away with and utterly destroys (in logic, though not in fact) the creative activity of man. Nothing can be more sure than that science and scientific method do not and cannot govern the whole of human life: man is not always in subjection to scientific rules, and he actually does a great deal for which no such rules can be given. This other side of human life is the creative, the poetic activity of man. Without this side, man would have no history, and the world would be a mere mechanism; but inasmuch as he possesses it, he is not bound but free, so that he can achieve, create, invent. His creative power is of course limited, precisely as science is limited. They are in fact two reciprocal functions; neither one can dispense with the other. The scientist cannot do without the poetic faculty, any more than the poet can afford to disregard the law of gravitation.

Plato paid no heed to this truth when he made his attack upon poetry and art.¹ What we call poetry is nothing but one manifestation of

¹ Cf. Jowett, *Dialogues of Plato*, ii, p. 120: "The philosopher may be excused if he imagines an age when poetry and sentiment have disappeared, and truth has

man's creative power, a power which is necessary to human life. Plato tried to construct a world in which there should be no creation, no change, no poetry, a world of absolute and immutable Being, a scientific world. He followed the argument whither it took him; he was intensely logical.¹ But his premises were wrong, as I said above. He thought that scientific truth was the only reality in the universe. To appreciate how serious was his error and how far-reaching its consequences, one has only to follow in the *Republic* his working-out of the doctrine of ideas. Plato's dialectic is predominantly surgical; he reforms by cutting away. This world in which we live is at a half-way stage between existence and non-existence; it can be brought into conformity with existence, which is absolute truth, only by resolutely excising all the elements which are properly non-existent and false.² As we look about us we seem to behold incessant change, birth and decay; the phenomenal beings we call men appear to be swayed and torn by wild appetites and passions, to love and hate, to be born and suffer and die. None of these things are true, if we fix our eyes not on appearances but on reality; and our set purpose (*qua* Platonists) to reform this world of appearances depends for its fulfilment upon our ability to abolish, so far as we possibly can, all that causes change and error, whether the change be external to us or take place in our souls. Emotions and appetites are the beast of unreason in man;³ the only good and tolerable emotion is the Platonic Eros, the love of knowledge.

Thus Plato's desire to do away with emotion was enough to bring him into conflict with poetry. Plato was aware that not he only but all Greeks were profoundly moved by their poets, easily stirred to pity and to laughter; this he makes the heaviest count in his accusation, saying that "the poets satisfy and delight" that natural feeling in us taken the place of imagination, and the feelings of love are understood and estimated at their proper value." One is at a loss how to deal with such statements. How can a philosopher, whose business it is to recognize the truth, ever be excused for imagining a falsehood, for denying imagination, and for sneering at love?

¹ *Rep.* 394 D.

² Cf. *Rep.* 585. From this conception is derived the inhumanity of Plato, his hatred and contempt for the crowd; he shrank from the facts of human life to such an extent that he was forced to create a mythical monster, compounded of man and lion and serpent, instead of courageously admitting that man always was and always will be an animal.

³ *Rep.* 586 A.

"which is just hungering after sorrow and weeping."¹ Plato was therefore compelled either to forswear the very heart of his doctrine, or to expel from the state the poet as a disturber of the soul's peace and health.² We hear so much about Plato and myths, Plato and mysticism, Plato the great artist, that we are inclined to forget that he was one of the sternest and most thorough logicians that has ever lived, and to forget how intense was his faith in the conclusions to which his reason led him. Plato's expulsion of the poets was no mere metaphor, but was profoundly serious and earnest.

This decree, however, was not yet sufficiently broad-based to satisfy Plato: for the poets professed to teach mankind, to give good counsel, and to make men better in their cities, — a claim which was directly antagonistic to Plato's philosophy.³ It would have been suicidal for him to grant their claim; if the poets were right there was indeed no ground for his philosophical existence, and the philosopher who had asserted his monopoly of wisdom was doomed. He believed that truth could be attained in one way only; and that way was the one he advocated.⁴ The fight for his philosophical life was in itself an adequate reason for his denunciation of the poets; it forced him to prove that their assertions were false in every particular, that there was no truth in them and no possibility of the truth being in them. To meet this exigency he employed the famous theory of imitation. It behooves us to tread carefully here, because the real import of this theory has been so often misapprehended.

The real world is made by God, and consists of absolute and immutable Forms.⁵ Strictly speaking, He is the sole artisan and sole creator. On earth, however, we have men who at one remove imitate

¹ *Rep.* 604 ff. Cf. 606 D: "And the same may be said of lust and anger and all the other affections, of desire and pain and pleasure which are held to be inseparable from every action, — in all of them poetry feeds and waters the passions instead of withering and starving them."

² *Rep.* 398.

³ Cf. Murray, *Rise of the Greek Epic*, pp. 1 ff., and the references there given.

⁴ Plato's aristocratic impulses found expression in an aristocratic and exclusive doctrine. Hence "the real ruler must be a philosopher; and the philosophic nature is reserved for a few rare souls: 'a whole people cannot be a people of philosophers'." (Barker, *Political Thought of Plato and Aristotle*, p. 110).

⁵ *Rep.* 596, 597.

these heavenly Forms; if the Form be of a bed, we call the prime earthly imitator a manufacturer of beds. The beds which he makes are like reality, but not perfectly real; for they are at one remove from the perfect reality which is in heaven, although they are the best which are in this world, and represent the nearest approach to perfection which can be made by man. Therefore the manufacturer of beds and any one else who imitates at first hand has a right to exist. But the poet has no such right; for he merely talks about what other people do, make, and think. He imitates an already imperfect imitation; i. e., he imitates a phantasm and not the truth, from which he is twice removed. The result is completely divorced from truth: only children and fools will take it for reality.

Thus Plato proves his point: and thus a sophistical and unjust argument was begotten, whose numerous progeny have darkened the discussion of aesthetic and literary theory ever since. It has been said that the ideal of history is "*tout comprendre et ne pas s'indigner*"; but it is a false ideal. Not to understand is perhaps inexcusable, but not to be indignant at this vicious doctrine of Plato's is to make oneself partaker in his crime; it is to banish life from literature, as well as literature from life. Plato did not engage in a fair fight with poetry: he struck it from behind with a deadly weapon — the theory of imitation, and his pupil Aristotle, who adopted the theory and made it the foundation of all he said about literature, affords us a fascinating and instructive spectacle.¹ In the hands of the skilful Aristotelian dialectic, the offensive weapon of the master was transformed into an instrument of healing; and the wounds of poetry were staunched, though temporarily and imperfectly, by the very same tool which had been used to inflict the blow. The theory of imitation was employed by Plato to accomplish a special purpose, to achieve the ruin of poetry and art; and we have seen that Plato longed for this disastrous consummation because his scheme of the universe was incomplete, because he

¹ Finsler, *Platon*, pp. 14–26, gives ample proof that "Platon am Ende seines Lebens die gesamte Poesie ohne Ausnahme als Nachbildung bezeichnet hat, und zwar ganz unabhängig von allen ausser ihr liegenden Gesichtspunkten." We can never get at the truth about Plato so long as we regard his use of the term *mimesis* as a mere accident of phraseology; Plato knew what he was doing, and to regret its "disparaging associations" (Butcher, p. 121) is like regretting the "harsh treatment" accorded Charles I.

attempted to make the world wholly scientific and sought to exclude from it all creative activity. This error of Plato's was rapidly transformed into a definite system of aesthetics and of criticism; and it has profoundly influenced all men and all things which have since come into contact with it, be they little or great, Horace or Aristotle, the Alexandrian grammarians or the mediaeval scholastics, Scaliger, Boileau, Pope, or Taine and Brunetière and Norden.

In particular, I wish to show its intimate and vital relation to the twin doctrines of literary form and of decorum to which Cicero and Horace adhered. This relation will become manifest as soon as we have set forth the terminology employed by Plato in his theory of imitation. It is hardly possible to exaggerate the influence which, through the medium of this theory, Plato has exerted upon the subsequent history of literature; and we shall discover that the conjunction of this theory with the doctrine of ideas has determined all the ordinary formulas of criticism.

1. The perfection of reality, of reason, of science, of truth, is expressed by the words *εἶδος* or *ιδέα* (form, shape).¹ These perfect *εἶδη* or *ιδέαι* are in and constitute nature (*φύσις*); it may be said that god is their maker (*θεὸν ἐργάσασθαι*) or that he is the creator of nature (*φυτουργός*) or that god is he who makes by virtue of nature (*φύσει πάντα πεποίηκεν*). Nature is itself perfect and is indistinguishable from the *εἶδη*.²

2. At one remove or separated by one generation (*γέννημα*) from perfection are all the phenomena of this universe, both things and men. The maker of a phenomenal bed or table (such as we actually use) makes it by copying the real shape (*πρὸς τὴν ιδέαν βλέπων*);³ he acts as agent of the shape, and the result is not of course real, but is a semblance of reality (*τι τοιοῦτον οἶον τὸ ὄν*).⁴ The duty of the philosopher is to extract and abstract the reality from the semblance, by means of

¹ I should apologize for repeating this familiar terminology, were it not so necessary for my argument. See *Rep.* 596 ff., or any good account of Plato's doctrine.

² Cf. A. W. Benn, *The Greek Philosophers*, p. 233: "The sense of supreme and absolute reality belongs in a much higher degree to the Platonic *φύσις* than to the nature of modern or even of Aristotelian philosophy."

³ 596 B.

⁴ 597 A.

dialectic: dialectic is the "only method which attempts systematically to form a conception of the real nature of each individual thing."

3. One remove further away from reality is a third class of things, which are imitations of the semblances of reality. For example, the real bed is an *εἶδος*, the phenomenal bed is a copy of the *εἶδος*, but the "bed" which is made by a painter is a copy of a copy.¹ Therefore it has no part nor share in reality or truth; it is a mere imitation.² It cannot deceive the elect, but it does deceive children and thoughtless men.³ The makers of such imitations are painters and poets; they are imitators and sorcerers, who pretend to have all knowledge but actually have none.⁴ If they had, they would not imitate phantasms, but would try to copy reality; that is, they would abandon art for science.⁵ "Do you think that if a man could produce both the original and the imitation he would give himself up to the manufacture of the imitations, and make this his object in life, under the idea that he professes a most noble purpose?" Thus science utters through Plato the decree of banishment from the state.

The decree is entirely justified, if the premises be admitted: nevertheless Plato makes one illogical exception to the execution of the decree, in that he permits hymns to the gods and panegyrics on good men.⁶ In this case, Plato clearly allows his feelings to overcome his reasons: his motive is laudable, but the act is due to what we call "human weakness," as when a man who believes exclusively in organized charity gives alms to a beggar.⁷ If, however, we summon Plato to defend his lack of logic, he will say: — "Though I banish poetry, yet I still love it with all my heart, and shall welcome any proof that poetry is not only pleasurable but also profitable; as things are, I can tolerate only the exception I have named, and that only on condition that the gods and good men be represented as perfectly good." Thus does Plato hint at the method of rescue, at the defense against his own indictment; a hint which was caught at eagerly by Aristotle.

¹ 597 B.

² 598 B.

³ 598 C.

⁴ 598 D. It will be noticed that Plato makes no less unfair use of the principle of division of labor than of the theory of imitation.

⁵ 599 A.

⁶ 607 A.

⁷ It has been suggested that Plato, very likely, had another motive: i. e., reluctance to interfere with established religious conventions.

Before going on to that, let us draw the inferences necessitated by the theory of imitation as we have outlined it. The perfect form of anything is called the *εἶδος* or *ἰδέα*. Suppose that we are looking at a particular bed (*κλίνη τις*) made by a human manufacturer: how shall we judge it, by what standard or criterion shall we criticize it? Plainly *we shall judge it by the degree in which it corresponds with or approaches to the perfect form or εἶδος*. Although the phenomenal object never can be absolutely perfect, we must strive to make it *conform* as nearly as possible. Moreover, we shall criticize in terms of excess and defect: that is, we shall discover that the particular bed either lacks some of the qualities inherent in the perfect bed, or has some qualities foreign to the perfect bed, or both. We shall say it is too long or not long enough, or too soft or not soft enough. So with every other particular thing in the universe, including particular men: we shall praise and condemn by the standard afforded by the *εἶδος*, in terms of conformity to that standard. But this is the doctrine of propriety, and this is also the doctrine of perfect forms; this is precisely what we have been searching for throughout our investigation. The essential framework and system of these doctrines is therefore Platonic; they must apply to literature, for they apply to everything. As a matter of fact, Plato himself applied them to literature, both to poetry and to rhetoric. In the *Gorgias*, statesmen, sophists, and rhetoricians, are damned by the same argument which Plato employs against poetry; they must go, and their places must be taken by the true philosopher, since he alone can make men better.¹ Remembering the identity of scientific (that is, ultimately real) truth with the *εἶδη*, let us examine Plato's critique of Homer.

Since scientific truth is also (for Plato) moral perfection and since gods and heroes are morally perfect, a poet who represents gods and heroes as immoral beings is irreverent, offensive and injurious; that is, he violates propriety inasmuch as he is false to the perfect form. The poet must be compelled to impress upon his poems the likeness of

¹ Cf. *Gorgias*, 503 A: "Rhetoric is of two sorts; one, which is mere flattery and disgraceful declamation; the other, which is noble and aims at the training and improvement of the souls of the citizens, and strives to say what is best." That is, Socrates has set up a 'perfect form' of rhetoric, and has compared actual rhetoric with that perfect form; naturally it falls short of the ideal, and is therefore condemned, by parity of reasoning with the condemnation of poetry.

moral perfection; failing in that, he fails in all. The utterly nihilistic character of Plato's doctrine comes out in page after page. He does not merely expurgate, he excinds Homer. He leaves no place of shelter for art, and it would be impossible to write poetry in Plato's state. I should not insist upon an already obvious fact, were it not that so many literary critics have thought that they could accept his premises and escape his conclusions, that by some magic they could disentangle themselves from his almost flawless dialectic.¹ Plato, we may be sure, would have treated them as a saint later treated the Laodiceans. No man can logically reconcile Plato's theory of art with the continued existence of art. Plato could not reconcile the two, and he was no mean logician. However, we have seen what was the origin of Plato's error; we have seen how he employed the theory of imitation to serve his purpose, and how the twin doctrines of propriety and of the perfect form came quietly forth from their home, the doctrine of ideas. Let us trace a few steps in their downward career.

Aristotle, the great conservative and natural scientist, criticized the details of Plato's doctrine, but adopted its essential methods, and therewith its essential error. As the old saying goes, he criticized Plato as a foal kicks its mother. No logical compromise with the theory of imitation was possible; therefore Aristotle made an illogical compromise. He tried to accept both things as they are, and also Plato's realism. But Platonic realism means that things are not really as they are, but utterly otherwise. This is the reason why Aristotle invented his ὕλη; matter is the illogical stop-gap between things as they are and nature or φύσις, which is perfect and is identical with the εἶδος and with οὐσία and with the τέλος τῆς γενέσεως.² But one cannot introduce

¹ Cf. I. Babbitt, *Masters of Modern French Criticism*, *passim*. Mr. Babbitt is constantly appealing to Platonic definitions and to Platonic idealism to rescue us from naturalism and from the philosophy "of the flux." There is, however, no hope of rescue in Platonic idealism (or rather realism); naturalism and Platonic realism are both equally hostile to humanism, and the sooner it is recognized the better for truth and for criticism.

² Cf. A. W. Benn, *Greek Philosophers*, p. 289; he discusses Aristotle's notion of substance, and concludes "the truth is, that we are here, as Zeller has shown, in presence of an insoluble contradiction, and we must try to explain, not how Aristotle reconciled it with itself, for that was impossible, but how he reconciled himself to it."

such compromises between logic and fact without getting into difficulties; a single initial error vitiates the whole process. From this point of view, we can explain though we cannot justify the difficulties which beset the *Poetics* of Aristotle; for he brought them on his own head by his attempt to reconcile the fact of poetry with the Platonic theory of imitation. Aristotle sought to meet the two logically irrefutable charges made by Plato; i. e., that poetry is immoral, and that poetry is not in accord with ultimate reality.

Butcher has said that "Aristotle was the first who attempted to separate the theory of aesthetics from that of morals."¹ This statement is extremely misleading, and is based upon a false interpretation of Aristotle. On the contrary, Aristotle insists throughout the *Poetics* upon the morality of poetry; we cannot afford to forget that Aristotle was under the necessity either of answering Plato's accusations against poetry or of remaining silent on the subject of poetry. Plato had said that in the case of pity, love, anger, and all the mental sensations of desire, grief, and pleasure, "poetic imitation feeds and waters the passions instead of withering and starving them." Aristotle's course was plain. "My dear master," he said, "you are certainly right in saying that poetry has a powerful effect on the emotions; but your prejudice blinds you to the fact that the effect is not evil, as you say, but good. You denounce poetry because it stirs the emotions: I praise poetry because it expels them from the soul precisely as a purge expels evil from the body. Therefore the soul is made better by poetry and not worse. The function of poetry is moral purification." Thus

¹ Castelvetro, *Poetica d'Aristotele*, pp. 9, 116, 117, is more nearly right: "*Aristotele riprova con poche parole quello che dice Platone.*" Butcher, *Aristotle's Theory of Poetry and Fine Art*, has a very bad time trying to reconcile the *Poetics* with what he himself believed to be true. Compare these three passages: "art addresses itself not to the abstract reason but to the sensibility and image-making faculty; it is concerned with outward appearances; . . . its world is not that which is revealed by pure thought; it sees truth, but in its concrete manifestations, not as an abstract idea (p. 127): "the work of art was not a semblance opposed to reality, but the image of a reality which is penetrated by the idea, and through which the idea shows more apparent than in the actual world (p. 160): "since it is the office of the poet to get at the central meaning of facts, to transform them into truths by supplying vital connexions and causal links, to set the seal of reason upon the outward semblances of art, it follows that the world of poetry rebels against the rule of chance (p. 180)."

Aristotle introduced the doctrine of *catharsis* into his definition of tragedy; so far from abandoning the prevalent Greek tradition concerning the office of poetry, he confirmed it with all the weight of his authority. It makes absolutely no difference to the argument whether we interpret *catharsis* as a physiological metaphor, in the sense of 'purging,' or as a metaphor from the religious rite of lustration, in the sense of 'purification.' I think there is no doubt that 'purging' is the correct translation, but in either case the man whose emotions have been purified or purged is thereby made better; and since this is the end and ultimate justification of tragedy, tragedy has a moral purpose. The doctrine of *catharsis* is Aristotle's refutation of Plato; and, curiously enough, it may almost as truly be said to be Plato's refutation of Plato.¹ Plato repeatedly refers to the "purging away of pleasures and emotions"; and all Aristotle had to do was to extend the application of a process long familiar and to assert the morality of poetry by virtue of its effect on the moral nature of man. In this way a metaphor suggested by the medical practice of all ages and by religious theories current in Greece since the early days of Orphicism became a stately aesthetic dogma and a perennial source of discussion among the learned.

Aristotle had thus removed the first objection to poetry. To find an answer to the other accusation, i. e., that poetry has no part in the real truth, was not a difficult task for the man who wrote the *Organon*. Scientific truth, which meant to Plato knowledge of the εἶδη, meant to Aristotle knowledge of the universal, of τὰ καθόλου. But poetry, said Aristotle, is founded upon the universal, not upon the individual. It describes, not the kind of thing that has happened, but a kind of thing that might happen, i. e., what is possible as being probable or necessary. Hence poetry is more philosophical and of graver import than history, since its statements are of the nature rather of universals,

¹ Cf. *Phaedo* 69 C; *Rep.* 560 D, 567 C; and *Laws* 790, 791. For Orphicism, compare Burnet, *Phaedo*, *ad loc.*, and the *Early Greek Philosophy*, 88, 107 ff. Butcher's and Bywater's attempts to show that tragedy, according to Aristotle, has no direct moral influence, are most unconvincing. "Tragedy does not make men better, though it removes certain hindrances to virtue" (Butcher, p. 269). It is plain that if there is within a man something which hinders him from being virtuous, then the tragedy, by removing that hindrance, does more than a merely negative work.

whereas those of history are singulars. It is appalling to realize how an argument conceived for the express purpose of refuting Plato, a paradox employed against a deduction from an untenable theory, has reverberated through subsequent criticism. Suffice it to say that poetry is neither philosophy nor science, and that the attempt to identify the truth of poetry with scientific or philosophical truth is wholly indefensible. Poetry has nothing to do with universals. The attribution of universality to poetry was forced upon Aristotle by the theory of imitation; and his polemic is entirely contained within the limits of that theory. But that theory is false, and what is contained within it is also false.

However, Aristotle considered that he had thus cleared the ground for his treatise on poetry. Now comes the crucial moment for the history of criticism: in what way did Aristotle approach the actual task of judging literature? His acceptance of the theory of imitation compelled him to regard literature as an external product, and not as an expression; as something which man makes, and not as something to which man gives birth. We must resolutely free ourselves from the opinions we have already formed about the *Poetics* in the course of previous study, in order that we may renew our curiosity and get fresh impressions from the facts.

"Our subject being poetry, I propose to speak not only of the art in general but also of its species and their respective capacities; of the structure of plot required for a good poem; of the number and nature of the constituent parts of a poem; and likewise of any other matters in the same line of inquiry. Let us follow the natural order and begin with the primary facts."¹ The promise of Aristotle's first sentence is abundantly fulfilled in those that follow: his treatise is at once scientific and practical. He presents us with the earliest complete application of the doctrine of literary forms. Poetry, which is a species of imitation, is itself subdivided into several sub-species. These sub-species are literary forms; and it is of the utmost importance, for the historian of literature at least, that the Aristotelian method of criticism be fully understood.

His statements, then, are to be true and precise in the scientific sense; his definitions are to be mandatory both for the critic of poetry

¹ *Poetics*, 1447 A, Bywater's translation.

and for the poet.¹ To each definition is attached a penalty, which operates as automatically as any other scientific law: if you attempt to disregard the 'law' (or force) of gravitation, you pay the penalty by falling; if you attempt to disregard the law of tragedy, you pay the penalty, because what you have written will not be a tragedy. Conversely, if you obey the law strictly, the result will be a tragedy; and if you obey it perfectly, the result will be a perfect tragedy. If a critic take up your work to criticize it, his whole duty will be to see whether or not it conforms perfectly to the law. If it does, he cannot withhold his approval; if it does not, he must condemn it.² For in the eyes of Aristotle, a definition is a scientific law and an expression of ultimate truth; this is the reason why the process of defining is so enormously important in his philosophy. He believes that a definition must set forth the "actual lines of cleavage which nature has established between kind and kind,"³ and failure to distinguish between the Aristotelian *ὅρος* and modern usage has led to a great deal of loose thinking. When we define, we merely declare the sense which we intend henceforward to put on a word or symbol; whereas Aristotle taught that to know the definition is to know the thing defined, to know the form or *εἶδος* in perfection. In such wise did form become lord over the realm of literature and criticism as well as over all other fields of knowledge.

The all-important question for us, then, is to determine whether these scientific definitions of form are what they pretend to be, whether they do or can correspond to the ultimate scientific truth. Do such definitions possess objective validity? If they do, they must fulfil two requirements: they must explain all 'tragedies' or whatever form is being defined, and they must be capable of verification. The conclusion is, I think, beyond reasonable doubt, that such definitions do not and cannot possess objective validity. Compare them with a genuine scientific law, and they fade and shrink into desiccated and

¹ Through these Aristotelian definitions, which must state the absolute essence and the cause of the things defined, the Platonic doctrine of ideas enters into all the innumerable classifications which Aristotle undertook; both philosophers hold that Form is the ultimate reality.

² It is obvious that we owe this method of criticism to the Platonic forms. Cf. *supra*, pp. 51, 52.

³ A. E. Taylor, *Aristotle*, p. 23.

ineffectual abstractions.¹ For example, take those scientific laws which deal with the behavior of falling bodies: by their aid we can explain a given event, such as a man's breaking his neck, without reference to the date of that event. He may have fallen a century ago, he may fall a century hence; but we can tell with absolute certainty the rate at which he fell or will fall. If we could not do so, we should reject these laws: for their whole value lies in their power to furnish us with an explanation which shall be applicable any time and all the time. Tried by the same test, what becomes of the law of tragedy? Neither Aristotle's nor any other conceivable definition will assist us to explain any particular tragedy whatsoever.² Our knowledge of the law of gravitation affords us a peculiar but genuine scientific comfort when we pick ourselves up after a fall. We know what has happened to us. But no law of tragedy ever gave or can give a similar glow of satisfaction to the man who has just finished reading the *Oedipus Tyrannus* or the *Medea*: something very real has happened to him, but it is not susceptible of scientific explanation. In order to know the particular tragedy, we have to live with it; precisely as we have to live with a friend in order to know him. *The experience is in each case real*, and yet is extremely incapable of being expressed or explained by a scientific formula.

In like manner, let us examine the second requirement, in the name of which we demand that a scientific law be capable of verification. Verification means that we must not shrink from the facts, that we must take our hypothesis and plunge with it into the midst of reality. If it enables us to swim, to keep our heads above water and to meet

¹ It may occur to some one that I am doing Aristotle an injustice by comparing his laws of tragedy to the laws of natural science. I am not: as a matter of fact, it was Aristotle who did himself an 'injustice,' by attributing an even higher degree of reality to his disquisitions on literature than the modern scientist would to his hypotheses concerning the uniformity of nature.

² The vain endeavor to abide by the laws of Aristotle has conduced to the production of a vast body of error; e. g., take the sentence of Butcher (p. 270): "The private life of an individual, tragic as it may be in its inner quality, has never been made the subject of the highest tragedy." What do these words mean? Is not Lear an individual created by Shakspere? Is there any valid distinction between the private and the public life of an individual? What Butcher really means, as the following argument makes clear, is that he did not like Ibsen.

new waves, well and good: it has stood the test and we must stand by it. If on the contrary, the next novel fact cannot be met and overcome by the law, the law must go and not the fact. Now that is precisely the situation that criticism is in, so long as critics endeavor to establish 'scientific laws' of form. Their 'scientific definitions' of a particular form are always being refuted by good new work, so that the history of criticism has been the history of a long scramble to overtake these new facts; each critic has been forced to jettison the old laws and to make new ones, and the critic therefore always remains behind and not in the truth. If these arrears could ever be cleared up, if there were reason to believe that sometime an ultimate law will be correctly stated, then all would be satisfactory; but the arrears will never vanish, because the creative activity of man can never be imprisoned. Science may and does limit art; but it cannot control art. Poetry has a truth and a reality of its own; it is not subject to scientific truth and reality. The doctrine of evolution, which is another name for mystery, has been applied to the genres of literature, in an attempt to solve the admitted difficulty; but evolution does not touch the real problem of the validity of the genres. To say that things which have no scientifically real existence evolve is to pursue a dream.

It is therefore impossible to establish a scientific and objective definition of any form of literature. We might easily reach the same conclusion in another way: that is, by examining the mental process through which a critic goes in the endeavor to define. Tragedy cannot be defined in the void: the critic must have some works of literature which all acknowledge to be tragedies in the particular and concrete sense. The definition of the genus must be reached by combining the essential attributes common to all the species. But this means abstraction from the reality; it means that tragedy must be studied externally and not from the inside; that it must be treated as a given fixed product, not as a round truth but as a flat surface. The result is that the definition cannot be equivalent to the concrete fact and cannot possibly explain that fact, because the particular tragedy is not itself objective. On the contrary, each particular tragedy is an expression of the creative power of some particular man, and is a part of the author's life. Aristotle did not escape the consequences of the old Platonic error, and his definitions are necessarily invalid.

But that is not all. The fact that they are false and are based on a false philosophy did not prevent them from succeeding. This method to which Aristotle gave the sanction of his authority was followed implicitly by all the Peripatetics, by all the Alexandrians, by Varro, Cicero, and Horace. Herein lies its vast importance for the history of literature and of criticism. Definitions were altered from time to time to suit the changing conceptions held by individuals or by schools; but the fundamental assumption always remained the same, and each critic as he formulated his own doctrine thought that he had put in definitive words the ultimate truth, the veritable essence and *φύσις* of that *εἶδος*. Hence the stress laid by them all upon the corollary doctrine of propriety; for no concrete work of letters could be judged good, unless it were in perfect conformity with the *εἶδος* as defined by the critics. The curse of Alexandrinism was contained in Plato and Aristotle, for their doctrines had externalized literature and directed the attention of both critics and poets to rules and formulas, to the *εἶδος* with which (they believed) they must conform. Dogma was piled on dogma until originality succumbed, or the poor remnants of creative power were forced into extravagance and obscurity, the *Alexandra* of Lycophron or the *Technopaignia* of Simias.

As an example of such dogmas, we might take Aristotle's statement that the most important of the six parts of every tragedy is the plot, because "the plot is the end and purpose of the tragedy."¹ We have become so habituated to the use of such terms as "plot," "diction," and "character," that we do not easily nor at once realize the absurdity of such a statement. Let us examine the word: it is defined as "the combination of incidents, or things done in the story."² Aristotle separates plot from character, and argues that "a tragedy is impossible without action, but there may be one without character."³ Sweep away these abstractions, and look at the truth: it is plain that there can be no actions without actors, that every actor has a 'character,' that plot and character are simply names that we give for the sake of convenience to different aspects of a reality which is one and indivisible. The convenience which we attain by the use of such names is purely empirical and is not at all scientific; we have a right to use them, but we have no right to use them as if they were mathematical symbols.

¹ *Poetics*, 1450 A 22.

² *Poetics*, 1450 A 4, 5.

³ *Poetics*, 1450 A 24.

From this point of view we can see how intimate is the dependence of Horace upon Aristotle. The definitions of the genres, with their imposing air of finality, actually varied in terms according to the subjective prejudices and the dominant interests of each critic; but they were always made out of the same material and by the same method. Now a mechanical concept, like any machine, is worn out by constant use; and this is exactly what happened to the conception of the *εἶδη* of literature. The elaborate definition of tragedy given by Aristotle became a brief formula in the hands of his pupil Theophrastus;¹ and his careful scientific study, in the *Poetics*, of the perfect form had inevitably the effect of elevating various concrete poems into the position of concrete models. Take the case of epic: Aristotle says that "Homer is in the serious style the poet of poets, standing alone not only through the literary excellence, but also through the dramatic character of his imitations."² That is, Homer is a concrete example of success in the epic genre. The irresistible inference is that if a poet imitates the epic of Homer, he also will be a success. I do not see how we can logically find fault with any poet for making this inference; and, as a matter of fact, it is notorious that poets after Aristotle did make it. He had told them to comply with the laws of the genre or be poetically ruined; their answer is easy to understand. They said: "Show us, not merely a definition which our minds do not readily grasp, but also real specimens of poetry which conform to your rules, and we shall be only too glad to become perfect poets." Aristotle made it easy for them to believe that Homer had caught and fixed for all time the immutable ideal shape of epic; they looked behind them to the Golden Age, in poetry as in all else, and there was no bitterness or reserve in Horace's heart when he sang that he was *inventore minor*.³ Hence came the Alexandrian craze for canonical lists of approved poets and orators: hence came the cry of stifled originality, urging the Romans by day and night to study the *exemplaria Graeca*.

¹ Cf. Diomedes: ". . . ἡρωϊκῆς τύχης περιστάσις." ² *Poetics*, 1448 B 35 ff.

³ Many elements conspired to assure the place of the *inventor*. Euhemerism, admiration for the divine in man, was unconscious long before it became a system: witness the Greek attitude toward Theseus and Heracles, and the dictum of Aristotle, *Metaph.* I, 1, 14. The pity of it is that Horace felt that he was necessarily a lesser poet than Lucilius, not on account of Lucilius's poetry, but on account of his meter.

All this evil was implicit in the theory of imitation: Horace merely played his part in the historical unfolding of doctrines and methods which dominated the Graeco-Roman world. It is useless and foolish to search through the *Ars Poetica* for phrases which may be direct quotations from the *Poetics*; because the whole poem is a spiritual quotation of the *Poetics*, and is a quotation in the same sense that a child may be called a quotation of his father. We have had enough of Quellenforschung in the mechanical sense; it is time to study the parentage of the spirit. In this sense, there can be no doubt that Horace is the child of Aristotle. His literary theory is entirely conceived within the trammels of the doctrines of form and decorum. It is fortunate for us that his theory could not control his practice, that his poetical genius was too strong to be killed by his critical theories.

I cannot go further into the history of the doctrine of literary forms. We have traced it back to its philosophical genesis in Plato, and have discovered that an erroneous and inadequate method had an erroneous and inadequate beginning. Wherever and whenever it has been accepted by men, the consequences have been the same; sterility, mechanical reproduction, routine, or on the other hand, wild extravagance and uncontrolled vagaries in art and literature, — in every case, the death of sane creative spirit. Great play has been made with the antithesis between classicism and romanticism; like so many other antitheses, it is essentially false, and we must resolve it by transcending it. It is not true that Platonic idealism, when applied to literature, tends to encourage sanity: on the contrary, it produces results which are apparently paradoxical, either excesses amounting to mania, or a faith in mechanical routine which amounts to death. I am not arguing; I am calling attention to the fact that Platonic idealism has, for reasons which have been explained above, the same effect upon human life as the most materialistic and naturalistic philosophy. The Alexandrian age is an example; the Renaissance is another; and the nineteenth century is a third, with which we are all familiar. In no century have men put more naïve and pathetic confidence in the power of science to explain and to control everything in the universe; in no century have men committed wilder excesses in art and in letters. The one excess flows from the other: for whenever we persuade ourselves that there is no truth but scientific truth, whenever we try to compre-

hend and govern the human faculties in their entirety by science, we do not therefore succeed in eliminating and annihilating our creative powers, but, what is almost as bad, we leave them uncontrolled or aborted. In other words, we cannot, so long as we live, help being poets, but it is very easy not to be a good poet.

The same principle holds true of criticism. On the one hand, a vast number of critics who have been misled into thinking that scientific method will give us the whole truth of literature; on the other, a lesser body of anarchists, who believe in *picaresque* criticism, in the adventures of the soul among master-pieces. With the latter class I have no concern, for they have not perceptibly interfered with classical studies. But with the others we are all most bitterly concerned. They have sought to reduce criticism to a science; and, like Norden, they define literary history as the history of the transformation of the genres. They found their history upon form, upon the *εἶδος*; we have criticized their foundation, and we have shown that it does not correspond to the truth. We have taken a concrete literary problem, the *Ars Poetica* of Horace, and followed the work of its critics through four centuries. They never grasped the reality, because their critical method absolutely precluded that happy result (except as they uttered truth accidentally, and out of relation to their system); let me recall their method in the light of our conclusions.

Each of the two schools thought, as Aristotle would have thought, that the problem which they had to solve was a problem of classification and of definition; that the ultimate question was whether the *Ars* belongs to the didactic or to the epistolary genre. These genres were defined quite in the Aristotelian manner; a didactic poem possesses one very distinct set of qualities, and an epistolary poem possesses another distinct set. The next step was to decide whether the qualities actually discernible in the *Ars* correspond more closely to the ideal didactic or to the ideal epistolary poem. So far the two schools were in agreement, but at the moment of decision they divide; and the gulf between them cannot be traversed. For the decision involved the making of a subjective judgment, which could not possibly be controlled by scientific reasoning. However, the decision was made; one side voted "didactic," and the other "epistolary." The ensuing spectacle is instructive to a degree. Each school proceeds to discover

in the poem which they have just classified all of the qualities which belong by their own definition unto that class. If any one of these qualities is lacking, or is present in defective or excessive quantity, the critics at once objurgate or apologize for Horace, according to their mood and their temperaments. Hence, for example, Weissenfels says that Horace "exceeds the permissible limits of capriciousness"; Weissenfels has stored in his mind a Platonic ideal form of the epistolary genre, in which a certain fixed amount of caprice is not only permitted but is required. Hence Norden, whose ideal of the isagogic form requires that the poem be addressed to the son of the author, apologizes for Horace's dedication to the Pisones, on the ground that Horace, being unmarried, could not after all have been expected to dedicate the *Ars Poetica* to a son of his own. These, it may be said, are minor absurdities. A major and a fatal absurdity is implicated in the very nature of such criticism. For the critic first attributes certain qualities to a given class, and then extracts those qualities from each representative of that class; a process which adds no more to our knowledge of the individual specimen than does the packing and unpacking of a portmanteau.

What then ought we to do? Are we condemned to nihilism and diletantism, to a career of trifling? On the contrary, there is a method of literary criticism which is not only better worth while, but is infinitely harder and more solid than the pseudo-scientific method. It demands of the critic that he be both scientist and poet at the same time. By the aid of science, he must labor to establish the objective facts, to know the texts and the monuments, to know the material facts of the past, everything which is a matter of record. If he is studying Euripides, he must know everything which can scientifically be known about Euripides and all his works. But even when he has reached that stage, his task is scarcely begun. Before he can explain Euripides to us, before he can write the history of Euripides, he must employ to its uttermost his own creative power, his own poetic faculty. Therein lies the greatest difficulty of criticism; and yet, unless we surmount this difficulty however partially and imperfectly, the truth is far removed from us. For to understand a work of literature is to understand a man, somehow to stretch and torture our own creative power, which alone can give us insight, until we have repeated in ourselves

quam longo intervallo the creations of genius. To criticize is to re-create, to live over again that portion of a great man's life which found expression in a tragedy, a lyric, or in a *Phaedo*. The name which we apply to any particular work of literature is a mere convenience: the ultimate reality is the spiritual life of the author of that work. The doctrine of literary forms has always turned away our eyes from that reality, has caused us to rest content with a futile label.

This does not mean that the true critic is stripped of his judgment, and is devoid of the power of selection, of the duty to praise or to condemn. Rather it means that all praise and condemnation must be of the man who is author and creator, and not of the plot or the subject or any other Platonic abstraction. Gilbert Murray, in his *Rise of the Greek Epic*, quotes a remark of Mr. Mackail "that in the *Iliad* we have a second-rate subject made into a first-rate and indeed incomparable poem by the genius of a great poet," and continues: "I think this view would probably be widely accepted. Many scholars would agree, with a pang, that the subject of the Wrath was not quite in the first rank of nobleness."¹ This is a good sample of the Platonic fallacy; and is worth testing.

Homer presents us with his vision of human life. Its value depends upon his creative power, his personality. If his creative power is slight and inadequate, then his poem is necessarily ill-conceived, and is partly dead; we shall have a right to condemn it, and so to dispraise Homer. But if his creative power is great, then the poem is entirely alive, and we have no right to condemn it except on one condition; i. e., unless it convinces us that Homer was himself an evil and not a good genius. If as we read we feel a shudder of horror at the evil personality of the author with whom we are associating, if we are persuaded that Homer hated the good and loved the cruel and the base, then we must condemn him as we condemn a Borgia. But no sane man can read Homer without being stirred by a genius who was not only great but fine and pure and high. Homer did not "choose a second-rate subject"; his subject is human life, which is the 'subject' of all poetry. Until we have eliminated from human life the "crude pride and self-absorption, the cruelty and lack of love" (which qualities as they are displayed by Achilles cause Murray to denounce the 'subject' of the *Iliad*),

¹ *Rise of the Greek Epic*, p. 251.

we have no right to condemn Homer or any other poet on such grounds. We might as well say that Shakspeare is immoral because Macbeth was a murderer and Othello was jealous.

For similar reasons we must abolish the old method of *Quellenforschung*, which required us to "separate the borrowed element from the personal element" of poetry before we could make a just estimate of the personal element. This method goes on the crass assumption that literary truth is identical with scientific truth. Take a textbook on chemistry; it is perfectly possible for a chemist who has studied the book to discriminate between "old" and "new" truths contained therein, to tell how much is borrowed and how much is a fresh and personal contribution. Scientific truth is a body of objective truth which can be and is extended by discovery. But literary truth is not created in that way, nor can it be weighed and measured in that way. Catullus and Horace did not take the Greek authors with whom they were acquainted, select portions of their work, and then add thereto some new truth which was their sole personal achievement. On the contrary, all the literature which they read and heard passed into their own souls and became, not a part of their stock-in-trade, to be dealt out in the same condition as received, but an inalienable aspect of their own creative activity and life. Their originality is not decreased in the slightest by the fact that they have been influenced by Sappho or Alcaeus; it is profoundly enhanced. It is absolutely impossible to separate from their literary works a borrowed element, and then to appraise a personal element. A work of science can be translated; a work of literature cannot. It can only be transformed.

The absurdity of the *Quellenforscher's* postulate is due to precisely the same error which underlies the doctrine of literary forms; to avoid this error and its consequences, to be both scientists and poets, is the ideal that we must set before our critics and ourselves. So long as we put exclusive faith in scientific method, so long as we believe that literary history is a record of the $\epsilon\ddot{\upsilon}\delta\eta$ and their changes, so long we are doomed not to know the truth, to falsify criticism, and to misunderstand the past.¹

¹ I desire to express my indebtedness to A. A. Howard and C. H. Moore for their kind suggestions, and to acknowledge my obligations to Sir Henry Newbolt's brilliant articles on the meaning of poetry.